

BITCOIN: THE SOLUTION TO THE MARK OF THE BEAST



“And he causes all, the small and the great, and the rich and the poor, and the freemen and the slaves, to be given a mark on their right hand or on their forehead, and that no one may be able to buy or sell except him who has the mark, that is, the name of the beast or the number of his name.”

– Revelation 13:16–17

“If anyone worships the beast and his image and receives a mark on his forehead or on his hand... he shall be tormented in fire and brimstone... and the smoke of their tormenting goes up forever and ever; and they have no rest day and night, those who worship the beast and his image, and whoever receives the mark of his name.”

– Revelation 14:9–11

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Prologue

You shall not inscribe any marks upon you; I am [the Lord] Jehovah.
– Leviticus 19:28

And he causes all, the small and the great, and the rich and the poor, and the freemen and the slaves, to be given a mark on their right hand or on their forehead, and that no one may be able to buy or sell except him who has the mark, that is, the name of the beast or the number of his name.
– Revelation 13:16-17

I've been working on a new electronic cash system that's fully peer-to-peer, with no trusted third party.
– Satoshi Nakamoto, 2008 [1]

February 2026

It was one evening when I sat down with a brother in the church to talk about the second coming of Christ and the end times, a topic almost all young Christian brothers are curious about.

“Christ is coming back, right? I mean, that’s like basically the central plot of the Bible.”

“Yeah of course.” He replied.

“But because the true Christ returns, the Antichrist must first come.”

“Yep, and then also the False Prophet (Rev. 13).”

“I feel like all Christians know that the Lord will return, but few truly know the significance of the things that must take place before the Lord comes.”

“Yeah... they must all quickly take place before the Lord comes back (Rev. 1:1) ...”

“That’s right, the Antichrist will come, and with him the mark of the beast...” I was getting a little excited, and continued. *“And he will literally force everyone alive on the earth to receive his mark (Rev. 13:16), and those without the mark cannot buy or sell, which means you cannot use money, as money facilitates buying and selling simultaneously.”*

“Yes, when the Antichrist comes, all your money will be useless, so you should store up for yourself treasures in the heavens.” He replied.

Now that was such a good scriptural reply, I thought, but it is by no means an answer to the reality that eight billion or more people will face in the foreseeable future!

“Think about it though,” I said. *“In this day and age, the power to turn off your ability to use money is equivalent to turning off your life! Like, nowadays you wouldn’t survive for a month without*

using money, no food, no water, no power, no fuel, no nothing, and the Antichrist is challenging the whole world to do that for three and a half years!”

I continued. “I mean, how many people will starve to death without the ability to buy food, or in fact without the ability to buy anything? So out of necessity just to survive, people will have no choice but to get the mark of the beast! They will probably say: ‘for some reason, to be able to use your money again, you only need to get a mark from the government on your right hand or forehead.’”

“Yeah, so people are definitely tricked to get the mark.”

“That’s right, the Bible says that people will be deceived into getting the mark of the beast (Rev. 19:20) ... I mean, by taking away everyone’s ability to use money (thereby, the ability to live) and promising to give it back with “just” the requirement of getting something on their body. That is such a simple, effective, and cunning way to get people to get the mark!”

At this point, I have never come to know how well designed the mark of the beast is, or considered the seriousness of this topic, but what is next might send chills down your spine.

“If you go to the next chapter, Revelation chapter 14, it seems that all those who received the mark of the beast will likely go to the lake of fire (Rev. 14:9-11).”

“Yeah that’s true, and there’s nothing said in the Bible that the mark is reversible, similar to our salvation,” I added. “But surely what will happen to those still alive on the earth when the Antichrist comes? Like the “sheep” the Lord said as the people that will take care of God’s persecuted people during the great tribulation (Matt. 25:31-40), how will they survive, and take care of others if they can’t use money?”

A very tough question, I know.

“The Lord will provide. He is sovereign over everything, so I believe there will be a way out for people from the mark of the beast. God desired all to be saved (1 Tim. 2:4), I think He wouldn’t just do nothing and let everyone get the mark.”

“Add Satan’s will is exactly opposite to God’s, so he desires all to perish in the lake of fire, hence such a clever scheme with the mark.” I said.

“Yeah, that’s right.”

“If only we could return to the good old days of the Old Testament where everybody used gold and silver as money, and held it in their own bags, then no one can stop anyone from using money, unless by force, as people are their own bank. That way, the mark would be useless, and billions of people would actually be saved!”

“That’s clearly not the case now, that’s why you need to preach the gospel more! Don’t talk about eight billion people, if you don’t preach the gospel, you can’t even get eight people saved haha.” He said tongue-in-cheek.

“Yes, haha. I really haven’t been talking about the good news as much as I should’ve...”

There must be a solution, I thought in my heart, God will always provide a way out.

Fast forward to today, it has been around two millennia since God humbled Himself by becoming a man to walk on the earth (Phil. 2:5-7), to willingly die for the sins of the whole world (Phil 2:8; 1 Pet. 2:24), resurrected from death (Matt. 28:7), ascended to heaven (Acts 1:9-11), and made the promise to quickly return (Rev. 22:7, 12, 20). Yet, contrary to the early apostles’ and almost every generation of Christians’ beliefs that the Lord will return in their lifetime (cf. 1 Cor. 7:29; 1 Thes. 4:17), the Lord seems to ‘delay’ His return.

One of the key reasons (not the whole) lies in the schemes of the evil one, Satan (whose name means ‘the enemy’ translated from Hebrew). Who plans to destroy the whole earth and all of humanity before the time of the Lord’s return. It is like God is an owner of a beautiful house and plans to host a great party (cf. Matt. 25:10), and Satan is malicious squatter who came to occupy the house and the things within the house for himself and his underlings (1 John 5:19). So in order for God, as the rightful owner of the house to host His party which He has been looking forward to for a very long time, He must first evict the squatter and his underlings (Rev. 20:10). However, Satan threatens to blow up the whole house and all the things in the house if God tries to evict him.

God, of course, being almighty, is able to rebuild the house into something better and more beautiful (Isa. 66:22; Rev. 21:1) and evict Satan from His existing house. However, he does not choose to do so, because he also remembers that He is a master artist and craftsman (Isa. 65:8), and has countless priceless vessels, works of art, and masterpieces (2 Tim. 2:21; Eph. 2:10), all one of a kind, and all-over inside the house. And Satan is exactly taking advantage of this by taking these vessels that are priceless to God hostage. God would have evicted Satan long ago and rebuilt a new and better house, but with the threat of losing all His personal priceless possessions (cf. Mal. 3:17; 1 Pet. 2:9), He has to use a sly roundabout way to rescue them, or make them immune to the imminent destruction. Then He can evict the squatter, and even if Satan does blow up the whole house in the process, God is able to reinstall His priceless possessions in a better house that He will build from the foundation of the old one, just in time for the party to begin.

As you might have already pieced together, in this story, the priceless works of art in the house, which are God’s personal treasure, is humanity (cf. Gen. 1:26-31; Isa. 65:8), and the house is the whole world (or earth). Most importantly to the topic of this book, the ‘bomb’ which Satan uses to blow up the house, is none other than the Antichrist, who is the destroyer, Apollyon (Rev. 9:11; Dan. 8:23-24). As it is written, the Antichrist (who is also known as the beast, the destroyer) will be given power from Satan (Dan. 8:24; 2 Thes. 2:9; Rev. 13:2) and destroy the earth and humanity in an extraordinary manner (Dan. 8:24; Rev. 11:18).

The Bible reveals many diabolical plans the Antichrist intends to carry out when he arises. However, for one scheme in particular, the Bible goes into greater lengths to describe, that is the mark of the Antichrist, the mark of the beast, which appears to be an integral, central, and universal part of the Antichrist’s operations (Rev. 13:16). The mark of the beast is a mark for

destruction by the destroyer, as all those who receive the mark will most likely perish alongside the Antichrist when this ‘bomb’ blows up (Rev. 14:9-11). Therefore, to diffuse the bomb (or render it significantly less effective), a solution must be given to “diffuse” the mark of the beast.

Understanding the mark of the beast is paramount, especially how the Antichrist plans to distribute it, and the reason why people are willing to receive it. And the answer to that is found in one line of the Bible. Revelation 13:17 has been the main burden of the author and the anchor of this book; it reads: “and that no one may be able to buy or sell except him who has the mark, that is, the name of the beast or the number of his name.” From this verse, we can conclude that the mechanism for the enforcement of the mark is through total economic control and coercion, and its twisted incentive is offering all to regain the ability to use money within a monetary system controlled by the Antichrist, by receiving it on the right hand or the forehead. When one’s ability to use money is equivalent to one’s ability to survive and live in our modern society, the incentive to get marked is especially irresistible. The mark of the beast is a “solution” offered by the very person who created the problem. It is like poisoning the world, then selling the cure, except the cure is deceptively much more deadlier.

We see that, as God is facing a dilemma with Satan, so also man will face a dilemma with the Antichrist, of either to receive his mark and face eternal perdition, or to lose the ability to use money and face deprivation and certain physical death. As I have remarked, if people are their own bank, and used a decentralised form of money that cannot be centralised, controlled, confiscated, coerced, and corrupted (which gold has functioned as, but not as perfectly), then the mark of the beast would lose its incentive and be rendered useless. From a purely selfish perspective, no one would willingly receive the mark if it provided them with no benefits. And this is where Bitcoin steps into the frame.

Contrary to the mark of the beast, Bitcoin seeks to impose itself on nobody, and as it continues to grow and accelerate in its adoption, it will be merited as a peaceful and neutral technology for the purposes of money: storing and transacting value across time and space, and not being subject to control or censorship from anyone, regardless how powerful they may be. And as a technology and tool in humanity’s shed, it will survive, thrive, or die for the very same reason the paper, the wheel, the fax machine, the lightbulb, the internet, or any technology survives or is phased out: if it offers its users the most benefit from using it for the purpose(s) it was created for. And common with the introduction of any novel technology in human history, Bitcoin has its technological barriers that users must learn to overcome. Most people will not consider adopting and using Bitcoin just yet, unless with a need to.

The following is from Ralph Merkle, cryptographer and inventor of the Merkle tree data structure utilised by Bitcoin for recording transactions, on the nature of Bitcoin:

Bitcoin is the first example of a new form of life. It lives and breathes on the internet. It lives because it can pay people to keep it alive. It lives because it performs a useful service that people will pay it to perform. It lives because anyone, anywhere, can run a copy of its code. It lives because all the running copies are constantly talking to each other. It lives because if any one copy is corrupted it is discarded, quickly and without any fuss or muss. It lives because it is radically transparent: anyone can see its code and see exactly what it does. It can’t be changed. It can’t be argued with. It

can't be tampered with. It can't be corrupted. It can't be stopped. It can't even be interrupted. If nuclear war destroyed half of our planet, it would continue to live, uncorrupted. It would continue to offer its services. It would continue to pay people to keep it alive.

The only way to shut it down is to kill every server that hosts it. Which is hard, because a lot of servers host it, in a lot of countries, and a lot of people want to use it. Realistically, the only way to kill it is to make the service it offers so useless and obsolete that no one wants to use it. So obsolete that no one wants to pay for it. No one wants to host it. Then it will have no money to pay anyone. Then it will starve to death. But as long as there are people who want to use it, it's very hard to kill, or corrupt, or stop, or interrupt.

While Bitcoin is a novel invention, the problems it stands to solve and its value proposition of being a form of money that is incorruptible, uncensorable, unconfiscatable, and under the full control of its owner are indispensable attributes that a form of money should possess during the times of the Antichrist. Understandably, it is easy to dismiss Bitcoin, or any novel technology, as a scam or misunderstand its utility without first understanding the problem(s) it is designed to solve. As it must, the first half of the book is dedicated to thoroughly dissecting the mark of the beast, with the first chapter of the book explaining the significance of the mark of the beast to all parties involved when it appears in the end times: to God, to man, and to the devil. We will specifically analyse why the Antichrist chose to place the mark on specific locations of the human body, and how these locations' Biblical symbolism reveals the intentions the Antichrist has for his mark.

The second chapter of the book discusses the person of the Antichrist, the person behind the mark of the beast as a big piece of the puzzle in piecing together the full picture. We will see how the beast was first revealed in the Bible through the prophet Daniel's visions, and zoom in on the person of the Antichrist in the apostle John's revelations. Chapter Two goes into great detail about the identity of the Antichrist and historical records of this person's conduct and deeds to illustrate the economic significance of the mark. Moreover, how the history of the early church and the records of economic persecutions faced by early Christians under this person's reign and his successors provide a picture of the socio-economic consequences of the coming mark of the beast for the whole world in the foreseeable future.

Similar to the second chapter, the third chapter will expose the person of the False Prophet as the last member of the satanic triad (Satan, the Antichrist, and the False Prophet). We will see how he qualifies to be the enforcer of the mark of the beast and deceiver as revealed through the Lord's unsettling remarks about him, and his occupation and conduct of his past life.

The fourth chapter confronts the gravity of the problem by examining both the consequences of receiving the mark and the irresistible incentive that compels people toward it. This chapter will unravel the blueprint and scheme of the mark before it has even come off the drawing board of the satanic triad, as the final groundwork and the starting point of our search for a solution to the problem of the mark of the beast.

As Christians and Bitcoiners alike know, holding onto what we have and what we believe in has always been a battle, and will always be. We are fighting a good fight. In any battle, intelligence is indispensable; understanding the enemy's stratagems and plans is instrumental to a victorious outcome. For this reason, the first four chapters of this book have been dedicated to exposing and understanding the problem, the architecture, and the scheme behind the mark of the beast.

Having laid bare the design, incentive, and severity of the mark of the beast, chapter five explains a very real and urgent need for a solution, and the requirements such a solution must satisfy to enable anyone in the world to endure through the great tribulation without submitting to economic coercion and the mark of the beast. By tracing the nature of money, authority, and control, this chapter exposes how the mark's single point of leverage: the ability to buy and sell, is also its single point of failure. If its incentive can be annulled, then it will be rendered useless. From there, it explores whether a medium of exchange can exist outside the control of centralised authority, and the necessary attributes it must possess to qualify as a solution to the mark.

Having arrived at Bitcoin as the sole medium capable of annulling the mark's economic coercion, a deeper question now confronts us: what is Bitcoin? To answer this, we must step back from Bitcoin itself and examine something far more fundamental: what money is. Chapter Six peels back the assumptions and prejudices we have for or against any form of money, including Bitcoin, by examining the first principles of money through creation, from Genesis to Revelation.

History often foreshadows what is to come, and it has a profound tendency to rhyme. Transitioning from theory to lived reality, Chapter Seven has been the most deeply heartfelt for the author to write and compile. This chapter is a collection of testimonies from individuals and groups among millions worldwide who have faced, and continue to face, economic repression and disenfranchisement. Drawing on events that occurred as recently as the turn of the 2020s, it reveals how all their stories unite around one notion that loudly echoes the economic reality of the mark of the beast: the weaponisation of money to serve the interests of the state.

And last but not least, after seeing the battle-testing of Bitcoin in the real world, serving as plausible scenarios that the world will witness under the reign of the Antichrist, it would be most appropriate to include a comprehensive but easy to understand guide to the utility of Bitcoin, as knowledge of the solution alone is not sufficient to constitute the solution without any application.

This book is written to help readers gain greater understandings into the pivotal event and device of the mark of the beast that must take place in the foreseeable future, and to present a methodical and critical scrutiny of the mark of the beast's incentive and design, and how it could be annulled with a medium outside of the Antichrist's control, thereby rendering the mark of the beast useless. The author, however, is not making an advertisement or invitation to buy into the bitcoin currency, neither is this book on theology or religion, and nor was it written in the realm of speculation. For from it.

The content of this book is provided for informational purposes only; it is neither authoritative nor complete. The author acknowledges the uncertainty of the future, and remains cautious that

the Bitcoin network may yet succeed or fail, and the mark of the beast may or may not occur in our lifetimes. All things are under God's sovereignty (Job 42:2; Eph. 1:11). The author holds onto the truth that the Bible is absolute truth, and the true word of God (John 17:17; 2 Tim. 3:16). Therefore, it is written with the optimism and hope that as cunning and effective the mark of the beast is, God will provide (or has provided) a solution to it, so that the people still alive on earth during the reign of the Antichrist would not succumb to the mark of the beast to suffering the same fate as the beast himself.

So far, Bitcoin, as a decentralised, global, digital, peer-to-peer, and control-resistant protocol, is the best candidate to address the mark of the beast in a foreseeable world of economic coercion. Should a medium of exchange emerge superior to Bitcoin in all the attributes and monetary properties discussed in the book (Chapters Five and Six), it would most likely be of the same principles, attributes, and properties that pertain to decentralised moneys like gold and Bitcoin, and be even more effective against the mark of the beast. For now, this book aims to illustrate how Bitcoin's attributes and monetary properties enable it to address the economic dilemma of the mark which no other forms of money can.

Equipped with such understanding from this book, and after thorough research and considerations into the practical aspects of owning, storing, and using bitcoins, should anyone consider holding value. Consider the simple analogy of riding a bike; the most important investment one makes is not the \$100 spent on purchasing the bike, but the 100 hours dedicated to learning to ride it safely.

This book might be read by people a century before the arrival of the Antichrist, or a decade before, or on the day when he arises, or even during the great tribulation. Should you emerge from this book believing Bitcoin is worth holding and using, or realise a need for it given your circumstances, your first investment should be time spent learning how to buy, store, secure and use it correctly. Bitcoin teaches that responsibility cannot be delegated or outsourced. When you outsource responsibility for anything, you effectively forfeit your ownership of it, whether it be knowledge, your bitcoins, or your savings held by a financial institution.

Without further ado, let's begin.

Chapter 1

The Mark of the Beast

Over the centuries, the mark of the beast has caused much confusion among Christians, endless theological debates, and evolving technology has never offered a clue as to what the mark will be. With the mark of the beast undoubtedly being a central piece, a kernel of the Antichrist's scheme operations in the end times. The focus on the understanding of the mark should not be speculations of what it will be, but rather, its significance from pieces of evidence given to us through the Bible, and the solution to the mark of the beast that these evidence guide us to.

Instead of speculating about barcodes or microchips, let us piece together the evidence found in the lines of the Bible. You may be surprised by truly how much information are dispersed throughout the scriptures, and by piecing the jigsaw together through examining the verses collectively, even more astounded by the coherent picture that emerges concerning the Antichrist and his mark. Equipped with the word of God, let us come to the full knowledge of the devil's schemes behind the mark of the beast, which are:

- The significance of the forehead and right hand
- The significance of its number
- The identity behind the Antichrist
- The identity behind the False Prophet
- The mark's deceptive incentive
- The mark's dire consequences
- And finally, the solution to the mark of the beast

Significance of Forehead and Right Hand

It might seem rather unimportant where the mark of the beast is physically located on the human body, but the Bible is specific about this for a reason. The devil selecting these two particular places of the body, the forehead and the right hand, is no coincidence, but in fact a blatant imitation of what God has done and will do for His people. We will see that our adversary is not a fool, but a deceptively cunning strategist, and his stratagem behind the mark of the beast is simple yet cunningly sinister.

The Forehead

In the scripture, the forehead is more than just an ordinary part of the body, it represents something profound in God's relationship with man. To understand this significance, we begin in the Old Testament in a time when God was laying out the rules for establishing a covenant relationship with His people. In Exodus chapter 28, God instructs Moses regarding the garment and attire of the high priest. Concerning the turban, God commands that a plate of pure gold be placed on it with engravings that display, "Holiness to Jehovah". This plate of pure gold with the engraving is fastened to the front of the turban (Exo. 28:37), that is, the forehead of the high priest. In fact, God says that this engraved plate shall always be placed on the high priest's forehead (Exo. 28:38) so that the offerings may be accepted before Him.

In the New Testament, when the Lord was asked the difficult question of what the most important commandment in the scriptures, Jesus's reply was clear: "love the Lord with all your heart, and all your soul, and all your mind, and all your strength" (Mark 12:30). In reference back

to the first time the Lord said this to the children of Israel in Deuteronomy chapter 6, the Lord continued with the explanation of the commandment: “and these words, which I command you today, shall be upon your heart... and you shall bind them on your hand as a sign, and they shall be as frontlets between your eyes” (Deut. 6:8). With the hand and frontlets of one’s eyes being the hand and the forehead, the Hebrew word for “sign” can be translated also as “mark” or “ensign”. It is fascinating that the only two physical body parts mentioned in relation to the first commandment of the scriptures are the hand and the forehead, with the writing on the forehead and hand later developing into the Shema, the Jewish prayer of devotion to God, a symbol of devoting one’s entire being to God. It is clear that God is commanding the Israelites to mark their foreheads as a sign of their complete love for Him, to represent that this commandment is at the forefront of one’s body and mind.

It is rather sinister when the Antichrist comes, he will choose to physically distribute his mark on the foreheads of all the peoples of the earth (Rev. 13:7, 14). In fact, did you know that something like this has already happened in history? Going one step beyond the metaphorical representation of the forehead in our devotion to the Lord in the two previous examples, a biblical event provides even more insight into the placement of the mark and the fate of those who receive it.

In the book of Ezekiel, the prophet sees a vision of Jerusalem under siege, where the judgement of God is coming upon the people of Israel and of Judah because of their very, very great iniquity. In this vision, God sent forth a man clothed in linen, with a scribe’s inkhorn by his side, to put a mark on the forehead of all the people in Jerusalem who are mourning and groaning over the iniquities being committed in the land (Ezek. 9:4). God then declared, all who does not have the mark, the old man and young man, the maiden, the women and the children would be slain (Ezek. 9:6; cf. Rev. 13:15-16). With the mark in Ezekiel in Hebrew denoting a “signature” according to Strong’s concordance, a stark cross-reference to how God’s people will have His name upon their foreheads in Revelation chapter 22, the conclusion and final chapter of the Bible.

Ezekiel’s vision of God’s mark upon their foreheads is an inversion of John’s vision of the mark of the beast in Revelation, or rather, the mark of the beast being the imitation and inversion of God’s mark of salvation. Through piecing together the scriptures, we realise that the mark upon one’s forehead represent one’s allegiance and ownership to the one giving the mark, just like the doorposts that were marked with blood of the lamb in Exodus when God passed over the whole of Egypt executing judgement, those marked on the forehead by God in Ezekiel were passed over as well (Ezek. 9:6) [3].

Going back to Revelation, we see the continuation of the mark of God, which concurrently opposes the mark of the beast. In the vision inserted between the sixth and seventh seal in chapter 7, we are told that the 144,000 from the twelve tribes of Israel preserved on earth by God shall be marked with the seal of God upon their foreheads (Rev. 7:3, 9:4). And ultimately in the last chapter of the Bible, continuing after the millennium and into the New Jerusalem, God’s name will remain on the foreheads of His people (Rev. 22:4), while the Antichrist and those with his mark are forever perishing in the lake of fire (Rev. 14:9-11, 19:20).

Just as how one put his name upon something to mark it for his claim, ownership, or possession, the mark of God is the name Christ and the name of God the Father (Rev. 14:1), while the

opposite, the mark of the beast is the name the Antichrist (Rev. 13:17), which will be discussed in greater depth later in the next chapter. Therefore, at the end times, there will be two marks operating in opposition to each other, one of the true Christ, and one of the Antichrist, both as an inscription and a claim to people with the names of the respective owners of the marks.

The Right Hand

While the forehead isn't the only location on the human body revealed in the Bible that people will receive the mark on, let us also understand why the right hand, in particular, is chosen by the devil and its significance to all parties involved in the end times. Indeed, after some in-depth research, it is convincing to say that this choice by the devil was likewise no coincidence.

Scripture reveals three things that the right hand symbolises. Number one, swearing, or the making of an oath. In the book of Isaiah, God swears by His righteous right hand that He will uphold Israel (Isa. 41:10). He also swears by His right hand and His mighty arm that when He establishes Jerusalem, Israel will never again be plundered by its enemies (Isa. 62:8). Hence, we see that God swears and establishes oaths with His people by His right hand, and evidence does not stop here. Let us travel further back in the Bible to see the picture of God's establishment of a covenant relationship with His people when He led them out of Egypt. We see in Leviticus that Moses anoints Aaron the high priest, whose position is the mediator of the covenant in the Old Testament, on his right foot, right ear, and right hand (Lev. 8:23). And going into the New Testament, the establishment of the new covenant come through Jesus, who is now being at the right hand of God (Rom. 8:34). Because of this, it is reasonable to assume receiving the mark of the beast on one's right hand represents one swearing a covenant relationship with the devil.

The second significance of the right hand is blessing. In Genesis, after Joseph is reunited with his family in Egypt, his father Jacob blessed Joseph's sons before leaving to be with the Lord. The blessing is given by placing his right hand upon the boy's head (Gen. 48:18). King David also echoes this idea many times throughout the book of Psalms. Psalm 16 says: "You will make known to me the path of life; in Your presence is fullness of joy; at Your right hand there are pleasures forever". David also exclaims how God shows His wondrous lovingkindness and saves by His right hand (Psa. 17:7). This significance is equally present in the New Testament. When revealing the things concerning the end of the age, Jesus refers to the people living on the earth as "sheep" and "goats", with the important detail that the sheep are set on His right hand, receiving blessing and inheritance from God (Matt. 25:33-34).

The third significance of the right hand is the representable of strength and action, with one of the signs of the commandment to love the Lord with all our heart, soul, and strength is to bind it as a sign on our hand (Deut. 6:8). In Exodus chapter 15, God's right hand was credited by Moses and the children of Israel with the smashing of the army of the Egyptians. "Your right hand, O Jehovah, is glorious in power. Your right hand, O Jehovah, dashed the enemy in pieces" (Exo. 15:6). King David, being a man of military prowess, referred to the power of the Lord's right hand multiple times throughout the psalms. In Psalm 20, David writes that the Lord will save His anointed with the saving might of His right hand (Psa. 20:6). We're told in Psalm 44 that Israel's conquest of old, were not done through Israel's own power or strength, but through the right hand and arm of God, and further mentions of the awesomeness and might of the right hand are a common occurrence throughout the Psalms (Psa. 45:4, 45:9, 60:5, 63:8, 89:13, 91:7, 108:6, 138:7). In addition to the power, might, and strength of God represented by the right hand, God

also shares in His might, to sustain and strengthen us by taking hold of our right hand (Psa. 73:23; Isa. 41:10, 41:13).

So how can these meanings and passages from the Bible help us in understanding the mark of the beast? Well, we see that the right hand represents covenant (the making of an oath), blessing, and strength when attributed to God. And for us, man, who is the image of God (Gen. 1:26), we can shake hands with someone to make a deal with deal, we can bless someone by laying our hand upon them (Gen. 48:18; 2 Tim. 1:6), or by simply giving them food or helping them up, and you can create and build using the strength of your hands as well as fight and protect yourself. Therefore, it is no coincidence that the Antichrist chose to mark the people on our right hand and forehead. With foreheads marked by the Antichrist, people are effectively owned and taken possession of by the Antichrist; and with right hands marked, people effectively partner with him, bless him, and give their strength to serving the Antichrist [3].

Chapter 2

The Antichrist

Let us unlock another big piece of the puzzle concerning the mark of the beast: the beast himself. Theologians often compare the Antichrist to influential world leaders or corrupt businessmen to speculate on his future identity. But to gain insight into his schemes regarding the mark and his claim to be God, let us compare the Antichrist with the true Christ to gain further insights into his stratagems.

The Antichrist is more than just a political figure or a self-coronated false god; so much evidence is scattered and buried throughout the scriptures concerning his person, conduct, and intentions. Let us begin piecing them together. We are warned in Paul's epistle to the Thessalonians that the Antichrist is introduced as "the man of lawlessness" and "the son of perdition" (2 Thes. 2:3-4). A man arriving before the return of Christ, and one who will claim himself to be the returning Christ and as god above every object of worship, taking a seat in the temple of God and setting up his images of worship (2 Thes. 2:4; Dan. 9:27; Rev. 14:9), proclaiming himself to be God. The Antichrist is first prophesied in the book of Daniel, among one of his many visions, and is further elaborated by John in the book of Revelation. And in the gospel of Matthew, Jesus spoke concerning this man of lawlessness in reference to Daniel's prophecy (Matt. 24:15; Dan. 9:27, 12:11).

	The Christ	The Antichrist
Claim to be the Messiah and God	The Lord Jesus is the Christ, the Son of the living God, and one with the Father (Matt. 16:16; John 10:30)	Claims and exalts himself to be God (Dan. 11:36; 2 Thes. 2:4)
Offered a deal to rule the world from the devil	The third temptation of Christ made by the devil in the wilderness (Matt. 4:8-9)	Satan, who is the ruler of this world, giving his power, throne, authority to the Antichrist (John 14:30; Rev. 13:4)
Making of a covenant with God's people	Christ shedding His blood for the establishing of the new covenant with His people (Luke 22:20; 1 Cor. 11:25)	The Antichrist will confirm a covenant with the children of Israel for seven years (cf. Dan. 7:25; Dan. 9:27)
Powerful beings in the end times	Will slay the Antichrist by the breath of His mouth (2 Thes. 2:8; Rev. 19:15)	Has global authority and dominance for a period (Rev. 13; Dan. 7:20-21)
Death and resurrection	Humble, quiet, secret, doubted by His closest disciples (Matt. 28; John 20:25; cf. Luke 24)	Displayed, open, for the whole world to see, to marvel, and to believe (Rev. 13:3-4)
Seven-fold intensified	One Spirit prior to the last week, seven-fold Spirits during the last week, the Lamb with seven eyes and seven horns and diadems (Rev. 4:5, 5:6, 19:12)	The beast had originally one head with ten horns in Daniel's vision (Dan. 7:20), and will have seven heads and ten diadems in the last week to parody the Lamb (Rev. 13:1)
A marking for their people	The seal of God on the forehead of His people (Ezek. 9:6; Rev. 9:4, 22:4)	The mark of the beast on the right hand or forehead of his followers (Rev. 13:17; 20:4)

A trinity	The Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit	Satan, the Antichrist, and the False Prophet (Rev 13:1, 4, 11)
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Both Christ and the Antichrist appeared in the ancient prophetic vision as powerful beings. They were both offered a deal with the devil himself to rule the world. They both made a covenant with God's people. They both claimed to be the Messiah and equal to God. They both will give their followers a form of marking to claim people as their own possession. And they both will play main character roles in the end times. There's even evidence contained in the lines of the Bible to suggest that the Antichrist will die and miraculously rise again, as an imitation of the true Christ's resurrection.

Therefore, we see that a key and recurring stratagem of God's adversary is, to be appropriately put, the shameless and blatant imitation of our true Christ and His works and accomplishments, by which he aims to deceive many, even the believers, into following him. As the Lord warned us beforehand that a time is coming when false prophets will arise and will show great signs and wonders so as to lead people astray, if possible, even the chosen. Many will be stumbled and fall away, even to betray and deliver up one another (Matt. 24:10-12, 23-24).

The Visions of the Beast

Over 500 years before the birth of Christ, a man named Daniel saw a vision that greatly distressed him. The vision of the four beasts that arose from the sea, corresponding to the four successive empires (Babylonian, Medo-Persian, Grecian, and Roman) that possessed dominion over the holy land since the captivity of the children of Israel and until the time of Christ's first coming. The last of the four beasts, Daniel described as different from all three before it. Its presence was terrifying, being dreadful, frightful, and exceedingly strong, with large iron teeth and ten horns. The beast devoured, crushed, and trampled (Dan. 7:7).

Presenting each beast as a metaphor of a great human empire. To the fourth beast, which is the last and greatest human empire in Daniel's vision, it was given for it to devour the whole earth (Dan. 7:23), meaning the last human government will exercise power over the whole earth. Revelation 13:7 confirms this, detailing that this beast is given authority over every people, nation, and tongue. To clarify any confusion about whether the same beast seen by Daniel (Dan. 7:7) and by John (Rev. 13:1) is a collective human government (or empire) or an individual, it can be explained that both interpretations are correct and reinforce each other. The beast, who is the Antichrist, is an authoritarian individual, and his government and authority are the enlargement of this individual, hence still the same beast. We see that the small horn (representing the Antichrist) that came up from the beast (representing his terrifying human government) is inseparably one with the beast, hence both the Antichrist and his government can be referred to as the beast.

And it is a great human government that the Antichrist will possess (Dan. 7:23-24). Among the beast's ten horns, a smaller one arose, uprooting three others. It has eyes of man, signifying the human appearance of the Antichrist (Dan. 7:8). With horns signifying might and power, the small horn arose to be greater than all other horns of the beast (Dan. 7:20) signifies that the Antichrist rise to a position of authority greater and more powerful than all the rulers of the last human government on earth. When Daniel asked for the interpretation from the angel that showed him the vision, the angel referred to the smaller horn that rose up as "he" and "his" (Dan. 7:25).

Explaining that he, the small horn, speaks things against the God, the Most High, and wages war with the saints and wears out the saints and will prevail against them (Dan. 7:21; Rev. 13:7).

The angel also points out to Daniel that he, the small horn, intends on changing the times and the law of the children of Israel (Dan. 7:25), aligning with his will of causing the sacrifice and the oblation written within the law to cease, setting up his image in the temple as an idol to defile the holy temple (Matt. 24:15; Rev. 13:14-15; 2 Thes. 2:4). And God's people will be given into his hands for a time (1) and times (2) and half a time (0.5), totalling to three and a half years. Incredibly, this corresponds to the length of time of 1290 days that the daily sacrifice is removed and the abomination that desolates is set up (Dan. 12:11) and the trampling of the earthly Jerusalem for 42 months (Rev. 11:2).

Undoubtably from Daniel's vision, the prophesy concerning the Antichrist from the vision of the four beasts reveals that the fourth beast, will exercise power and authority over the whole earth (Dan. 7:23; Rev. 13:7). And out of this empire (beast), the Antichrist (small horn) will arise from (Dan. 7:7), being greater than all other horns of the beast (Dan. 7:20). Nonetheless, as grim and terrifying as Daniel's vision in Daniel chapter seven may seem, which is alarming to us as equally as it was to Daniel, there is the Son of Man, the true Christ, also appearing in this same chapter. Daniel saw that Christ as the Son of Man was coming, and they brought Him before God the Father (Dan. 7:13). And Daniel saw that Christ will come, not alone, but together with His saints in His second coming to take away his dominion (Dan. 7:26; cf. Joel 3:11; Jude 14) to be given to His people and His saints (Dan. 7:27; Rev. 22:5).

Knowing that the words of the prophesy are faithful and true, it is reasonable to be alarmed in understanding the interpretations concerning the rise and authority of the Antichrist, as equally as Daniel himself was (Dan. 7:15). We do not yet know whether the mark of the Antichrist was a method that enabled him to seize control, or a method to tighten his authoritarian grasp over the world. Though both scenarios are plausible, one thing is certain: the mark of the beast carries an element of commerce. Revelation 13:17 reveals that the money of the people without the mark could not be used in buying or selling; a critical detail of the mark, which we will explore in greater depth throughout this chapter.

The prophecies and truth unlocked by Daniel, and later the apostle John in Revelation are certain, the Antichrist will be given authority over the whole earth (Dan. 7:23; Rev. 13:2) and over every nation and people (Rev. 13:7). And he, alongside the False Prophet, will exercise their authority over the world and will be ruthless in forcing everyone in the world, whether small or great, rich or poor, free or slaves, to be given the mark of the beast (Rev. 13:16). The choice to all of humanity in the last three and a half years (Dan. 7:25) is clear, receive the mark of the beast and worship him, or lose the ability to use money.

The Number of the Beast

John further reveals to us in chapter 13 that the mark of the beast is the number of the Antichrist, or a representation or symbol of his name, such as a number (Rev. 13:17, 15:2), to mark people out for himself. And John has provided us with the number of the beast's name, "666", and said let him who has understanding calculate this number (Rev. 13:18), hence we see that the number "666" is not literally or directly the mark or the name of the Antichrist, but requires understanding and calculation from this number to arrive at his name.

With the help of gematria, the system of assigning numerical values to letters in ancient languages like Hebrew or Greek, writers were able to embed hidden words or phrases in numbers. John cleverly revealed that the name hidden in the number “666” when decoded with Hebrew letters, is the name Caesar Nero, commonly spelled as Caesar Neron (Νέρων Καῖσαρ) in Greek. The extra “n” is not an oddity or modification, but standard grammar of Koine Greek spoken at the time of John’s writing, with the final “-ων” ending being a regular Greek nominative form for masculine names.

The Greek name of Caesar Nero (Νέρων Καῖσαρ) transliterated into Hebrew (נרון קסר):

Greek letters	Hebrew letters	Letter name	Number
Νέ	נ	(nun)	50
ρ	ר	(resh)	200
ω	ו	(waw)	6
ν	ן	(nun final)	50
Καῖ	ק	(kuf)	100
σα	ס	(samekh)	60
ρ	ר	(resh)	200
			= 666

Interesting to note, the Greek word “beast” (θηρίον) written in the book of Revelation transliterated into Hebrew (תריון) also amounts to the number “666”:

Hebrew letters	Name	Number
ת	(tav)	400
ר	(resh)	200
י	(yod)	10
ו	(waw)	6
ן	(nun)	50
		= 666

The number of the beast is the number of a man (Rev. 13:18), the man in question is no other than Caesar Nero. But what is even more fascinating is the confirmation of the name of the Antichrist found in a 3rd century manuscript of the book of Revelation, Papyrus 115, in which the most discussed section is its reading of Revelation 13:18. In many later manuscripts, this verse reads the number of the beast being “666” written in Greek using chi-xi-stigma “ΧΞϚ”. However, Papyrus 115 shows the number “616” using chi-iota-stigma “ΧΙϚ” in ancient Greek gematria [4].

Such a contradiction ostensibly throws a wrench into the interpretation of the name of the beast in Revelation 13:18, with two different numbers presented by separate manuscripts. However, the number “616” in Papyrus 115 in fact provides a confirmation of the name of the beast alongside “666”, and eliminates other potential candidates whose names also coincidentally sum to “666” when transliterated into Hebrew. Crucially, the alternative reading of “616” found in the early manuscript Papyrus 115 matches the Hebrew transliteration of the Latin form of his

name (NERO CAESAR) into Hebrew (נרו קסר), which drops the “ן” nun-final with the value of 50, thus summing up to “616”.

Hebrew letters	Name	Number
נ	(nun)	50
ר	(resh)	200
ו	(waw)	6
ק	(kuf)	100
ס	(samekh)	60
ר	(resh)	200
		= 616

Greek	English Transliteration	Hebrew Transliteration	Hebrew Gematria Sum
Νέρων Καῖσαρ	Caesar Neron	נרון קסר	666
Latin			
NERO CAESAR	Caesar Nero	נרו קסר	616

With the number two in the Bible representing witness or confirmation (cf. Deut. 19:15; Matt. 18:16). What turns out to be a discrepancy in the two numbers of Revelation 13:18 found in distinct manuscripts serves to confirm the name of the Antichrist, that is, the number of his name. Both the number “666” in John’s original writing of the book of Revelation and “616” in the manuscript Papyrus 115 refer to the name of Caesar Nero, showing how early authors utilised flexible numerical codes to point toward the emperor across different cultural and linguistic contexts within the Roman Empire.

Numbers throughout the Bible carry symbolisms and significance, with the examples of the number one representing unity (Gen. 2:24), two being witness (Deut. 19:15), and seven representing completion (Gen. 2:2). From Genesis to Revelation, the number six in the Bible represents humanity and imperfection: Man was created on the sixth day. Because six falls one short of the completion represented by number seven, it represents man’s state of being incomplete without God. It is equally intriguing to touch upon the number of the solution to the mark to be discussed in later chapters: Bitcoin. When asked among Bitcoiners what number is attributed to Bitcoin, the answer in consensus would be “21”. It is the author’s own interpretation that the number of Bitcoin, “21”, symbolically presents itself as “one-up” from the number of the mark, “666”, with “21” being a factor between 3 and 7 in multiplication, or the sum of three 7s in addition, implying the number “777” from “21”. Though this remains a compelling observation, it remains undetermined whether this interpretation and comparison between the two numbers is more than a coincidence.

As the Bible is full of types and figures, whether the coming Antichrist is exactly Nero remains yet unknown, and the author believes further hypothetical exploration into the realm of speculation will prove unprofitable. But as the name denotes the person, the Antichrist will most likely be a person who is, or most similar to, the person of Caesar Nero in his conduct and character. Having been named by John in the book of Revelation and confirmed by other early Christian writers as the coming Antichrist, to gain further understanding into the beast and his

mark, let us see what has been done by this despotic emperor in history in relation to the mark of the beast while he was once alive on the earth.

Neronian Monetary and Economic Control

The historical investigation into the reign of Caesar Nero (AD 54-68) reveals a consequential period in Roman governance and church history, one of biblical significance, characterised by the unprecedented centralisation of economic authority and weaponisation of monetary, economic, and financial systems to enforce political and religious loyalty to the emperor. Central to this period were the Neronian monetary reforms alongside the evolution of the imperial charagma (a transliterated English word from Greek, meaning mark or seal), which functioned not merely as a decorative element of the state bureaucracy, but as a vital mechanism for the regulation of commerce and the validation of state loyalty.

The Mark in the 1st Century

To understand the historical reality behind the mark of the beast in the times of the early church, at the time of the apostle John, one must first examine the technical and social applications of the charagma in the mid-first century. The charagma was a commonplace administrative tool long before the writing of the book of Revelation. In the legal and commercial environment of the Roman Empire, the charagma primarily denoted an official stamp, engraving, or seal used to authenticate government documents. Often bearing the image of the emperor and the year of his reign, they were essential for the legal recognition of bills of sale, rental agreements, and promissory notes [5].

The charagma functioned as a "legal signature" that carried the full authority of the imperial owner, providing the necessary security for transactions in a vast, disparate empire. Beyond the bureaucratic realm, the term extended to the branding of livestock and, more significantly, the branding of human property. Disobedient slaves were often "marked" with the charagma of their owners (cf. Rev. 13:16), a practice that designated permanent ownership and served as a visible warning to the rest of society [6]. This socio-economic context suggests that the mark required for buying and selling, or for any other permissioned activity, was likely perceived by the first-century audience as an outward sign of ownership and submission to the owner of the mark.

Nero's Authoritative Monetary Manipulation

The reign of Nero is distinguished by a radical departure from the established monetary system of the Roman Empire. Following the catastrophic Great Fire of Rome in AD. 64, the emperor faced a financial crisis precipitated by the immense costs of reconstruction and the development of his opulent Domus Aurea (Golden House). To address this deficit, Nero initiated an empire-wide debasement of the Roman currency, an act marking the beginning of state-managed inflation in the Roman Empire and the direct manipulation of the Roman monetary system.

Emperor / Period	Denarius Weight (Approx)	Silver Purity Percentage	Percentage Change
Augustus (Early Principate)	3.90 grams	98% Fine	Base Standard

Nero (Pre-64 AD. Reform)	3.75 grams	98% Fine	Base Standard
Nero (Post-64 AD. Reform)	3.41 grams	80% Fine	~25% Reduction in Content

By being the first Roman Emperor to exercise authoritative control over the empire's monetary system, Nero's reforms were not merely fiscal; they were an exercise of absolute imperial sovereignty over the economic activities of all peoples and tongues within the empire's borders. By reducing the silver content of the Denarius while maintaining its face value, the state effectively forced the populace to accept "fiat" value backed solely by the emperor's authority.

To ensure the success of this reform, Nero's administration took measures to remove older, finer Republican and early imperial coins from circulation, largely through recalls from provincial mints like Alexandria and Syria [7]. This policy of "recycling" old silver was a massive commitment by the empire to control the medium of exchange within its borders. For the citizenry, the ability to engage in trade was now explicitly tied to the acceptance of the emperor's debased coinage, a currency that bore Nero's image (cf. Mark 12:16) and his claims to divinity, such as the sun god Apollo [8].

Economic Activities within the Empire

The prohibition of trade without the imperial mark was facilitated through the social and religious structures that governed the Roman marketplace, particularly in the provinces of Asia Minor (cf. Rev. 1:4) and Judea. The macellum (public food market) [9] and the collegia (trade guilds) [10] served as the primary environments where an individual's loyalty to the state was tested and enforced through economic activities [11].

Guild membership often required participation in communal feasts and sacrifices dedicated to the guild's patron idol deity and the reigning emperor. For Christians and pious Jews, these rituals were inherently idolatrous. Refusal to participate led to exclusion from the guild, which in turn resulted in the loss of commercial privileges, the inability to secure contracts and leases for a stall, and a general "social death" that made it impossible to function effectively in the local economy. It is no wonder that the apostle Paul, being a tentmaker by trade to sustain himself financially (1 Cor. 4:12) did not join himself to any guilds of his trade, but to fellow Christians who were of the same trade (Acts 18:1-3). This exclusion was one of many foreshadowings of trade prohibition mentioned in Revelation 13:17, where those without the mark and do not participate in the compliance and worship of the beast would face total economic exclusion.

When the apostle Paul was walking through the streets of Athens, his spirit was provoked within him by the sight of many idols in public, one notable place of idol worship noted in Paul's gospel ministry in Athens being the marketplace (Acts 17:16-17). The macellum (public food market) was the central hub for the sale of meat, fish, and luxury consumables, and it was deeply intertwined with the religious life of Roman cities (cf. Acts 16:19, 17:17, 28:15). Records also indicate that these markets often housed shrines to idols such as Mercury, Neptune, and the divinised emperor (cf. Acts 17:22-23) as witnessed by the apostle. Therefore, significant portion of the meat sold in the macellum was "sacrificial meat", derived from animals slaughtered in

public religious ceremonies (Acts 15:29) [11], with the consumption of such meat quickly becoming a source of contention in early churches, most notably for the church in Corinth (1 Cor. 8, 10:25-31).

For the inhabitants of cities across the empire, the marketplace was by no means a neutral commercial space. The ability to buy food and trade within these markets was frequently contingent on acknowledging the imperial system that provided the market facilities. Under Nero, the monumental market of Macellum Magnum in Rome served as a prototype for this integration of state architecture, religious devotion, and commercial regulation [9]. For Jews and early Christians, the interference and mixture of the state and idol worship with marketplaces meant participation in essential economic activities, such as buying food, became impossible without making a compromise to their faith.

The Continuity of the Beast: From Nero to Decius

The authoritative control of currency and the leverage of trade access to enforce compliance to idol religion and the emperor were not isolated to Nero's reign. However, they established a precedent that would culminate in the third century. While the Neronian charagma was often sectoral or localised through guilds of tradesmen, it provided the administrative basis for the empire-wide libellus (meaning 'certificate') system under Emperor Decius (AD 249 - 251).

The Decian edict required every citizen to perform a sacrifice to the Roman gods and the emperor's well-being in the presence of a magistrate. Those who complied received a libellus, or certificate of sacrifice. Without this "mark" of approval, individuals were strictly prohibited from pursuing trades and conducting business in the public marketplace. Historians and theologians have noted that this prohibition conceivably goes back to Nero, as it represents the same "religion of loyalty" used as a prerequisite for economic participation [5].

The Neronian Principate thus served as the ground zero for the beastly economic model that would shape the rest of the empire's history, as seen in Revelation chapter 13. By debasing the currency, standardising the imperial charagma on commercial documents, and utilising trade guilds and marketplace as religious and political filters to economic activities, the Roman state under Nero was a system where the state could effectively embed a form of mark as a "right to participate" in economic activities. The inability to buy or to sell (economic participation in guilds and markets) without a mark (the charagma or libellus) was the ultimate manifestation of this authoritative control, adulterating the marketplace from its function of providing economic welfare into a site of idol worship and political submission.

The Economic Implications of the Mark

Though history does not repeat, it rhymes all too familiarly. The historical evidence indicates that the Neronian era witnessed the first cohesive attempt by the Roman state to centralise economic life around the person of the emperor. This was represented through three primary mechanisms of authoritative control: the manipulation of the currency standard, the bureaucratic requirement of the imperial charagma for commercial validation, and the religious gatekeeping of public markets and guilds. Nero's monetary reforms shifted the basis of economic value from the intrinsic worth of the silver Denarius from its metal content to the sovereign authority dictated by the emperor; a prelude to fiat currencies, a practice of state control and issuance of fiat money, where the value of currency is wholly determined and

dictated by the state. Such transition into the Neronian economy required the populace to place their faith in the “mark” of the emperor rather than the material reality and worth of the coin.

The prohibition of buying and selling written in Revelation 13:17 is a remarkably accurate description of the socio-economic pressures faced by those who refused to participate in the imperial cult of the emperor and the religious worship of idols. An issue highly significant and relevant to the early church during the times of the writings of the epistles (1 Cor. 8; 1 Thes. 1:9; 1 John 5:21) and the book of Revelation. Whether through the dilemma of social and economic exclusion enforced politically or culturally, devices or practices symbolic of a “mark” in the times of the Roman Empire represented the individual’s choice to submit to a system that demanded allegiance in exchange for economic survival. With the numerical identification of Nero through gematria serving as the historical anchor for this analysis, confirming that the early church recognised this system of totalising political, social, and economic control as the defining characteristic of Caesar Nero, the beast.

The Neronian precedent established the framework for later, more formalised persecutions, such as those under Decius and Diocletian, where the libellus functioned as the literal fulfilment of the trade-prohibiting seal. For the readers of the early church, the mark of the beast was no futuristic enigma, but a documented administrative strategy of the Roman Emperor initiated under Nero and perpetuated by his successors that the early church lived through, whereby the Roman state leveraged its control over the marketplace to enforce the worship of Roman deities, including the emperor himself. The history of the early church and the records of economic persecutions faced by early Christians under Nero’s reign and his successors of the past provides us a picture to the socio-economic consequences of the coming mark of the beast that will be enforced upon the whole world. A picture and warning that becomes ever clearer with the trend of ever-increasing centralisation and digitalisation of the world’s commercial, monetary, and banking systems.

The True Christ

Before we conclude this chapter, I would like to offer a word of advice. Researching about the Antichrist (and the False Prophet) will most likely lead you down a rabbit hole with no end. But I am certain that after finishing this chapter, you probably need to spend no more time in researching about the Antichrist, and you will naturally uncover more about his person, character, and plans as you journey through the Bible. So, don’t spend all your time and energy researching the Antichrist, when the true Christ is just exceedingly better.

It is true that we should not be ignorant of his schemes, but the best preparation you do is believe and receive the true Christ, Jesus, the Son of God. Know that whoever receives the true Christ, shall by no means be snatched after from His caring hands (John 10:28). Lastly, if you are fearful of the Antichrist’s rule, the Lord has a word of encouragement, turn to Him, and He will come to you, His love is perfect, and it will drive away all fear. And know this, if God is for us, who can be against us?

Chapter 3

The False Prophet

Having examined the person and stratagems of the Antichrist concerning the mark of the beast, it is appropriate to touch upon the last of the satanic triad, the False Prophet. Just like his peers, the False Prophet is known by multiple titles, namely, the earth-beast (Rev. 13:11), and he also plays a crucial role concerning the mark that merits its own exposition. Akin to the first beast, the Antichrist, the evidence concerning the identity of the False Prophet does not lead to a specific political or religious figure in today's times. However, biblical evidence does astoundingly present a picture of the person of the False Prophet to warn us of the reality of that person to come.

With Caesar Nero being the (picture of the) person, conduct, and character of the Antichrist, to know the person of the False Prophet, let us again piece together the evidence and context contained in the scriptures. The False Prophet as the land-beast is detailed explicitly in the Bible to have come “up out of the earth” in Revelation 13:11. The Greek word for “the earth” here is “τῆς γῆς”, or in translated in Hebrew as “ha aretz” (הָאֶרֶץ), meaning “the land”, a reference to the land of Israel, the good land. Though the literal meaning of the Hebrew term “ha aretz” does not objectively refer to any specific part of the earth, in the context of the Bible, especially throughout the Old Testament, the use of the term “the land” in hundreds of occurrences refers to the land of Israel, rather than a generic part of the earth (Gen. 48:4; Exo. 20:12; Lev 18:27; Num. 15:2; Deut. 1:8; Josh. 1:2; Judg. 18:2; 1 Sam. 13:3; 2 Sam. 5:6; Psalm 37; Isa. 5:8; Jer. 2:7; Ezek. 6:14; Dan. 11:16). Hence, we see the first beast came up out of the Abyss from out of the sea (Rev. 13:1), that is the Mediterranean Sea in the biblical context signifying the gentile nations, and this beast came up out from the land, signifying the land of Israel, revealing that the False Prophet will either be Jewish, or a person of Jewish background.

The appearance of the False Prophet reveals further details of his background and identity. His appearance like a lamb seems to be an open imitation of Christ (Rev. 13:11; cf. John 1:29; Rev. 5:6), as befitting to his prowess in deception (Rev. 13:14, 19:20). The first beast, who is the Antichrist as a gentile ruler's appearance was by no means similar to that of the true Christ's, nor was it pretending to be. But concerning the False Prophet's appearance as a lamb as an imitation of Christ, who is Jewish by genealogy (Matt. 1:1), is reinforcing evidence that the False Prophet may most likely have a Jewish background and originate from the land of Israel.

Judas Iscariot

According to the interpretations of Witness Lee and many other biblical teachers and scholars, the person of the False Prophet is most likely to be Judas Iscariot. Without speculation, the author will provide further evidence from the Bible that further confirms this interpretation. Lee noted in the book ‘The Prophecy of the Four “Sevens” in the Bible’ that Judas Iscariot uniquely went to “his own place” after he died (Acts 1:25) [12], unlike other instances in the Bible where a person goes to “his people” after their physical death, like for Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob (Gen. 25:8, 35:29, 49:33), Aaron (Num. 20:24), David (1 Kings 2:10), Solomon (1 Kings 11:43) and many of the kings of Judah (1 Kings 22:50, 2 Kings 20:21). Hence, those who were taken to a place which are not known by men are typically reserved for a reappearance later in time, such as Moses and Elijah, who will probably reappear as the two witnesses during the time of the great

tribulation (Rev. 11:3), and this is even true for Christ Himself, has gone to a place where we cannot go (John 8:22, 13:33), and will soon return.

Moreover, the smoking gun is found in John's gospel, the same author as the book of Revelation, as an apostle and coworker with Judas for three and a half years, and is further confirmed in Paul's writings. The apostle John, the author of Revelation, wrote in his gospel that Judas Iscariot is a devil and called by the Lord as such (John 6:70), and specifically named Judas Iscariot to be the devil which Jesus referred to (6:71). The Greek word for the "devil" written in John 6:70 is "διδόλος", transliterated in English "diabolos", and is the same word used to refer to Satan when he came to tempt Jesus in wilderness in chapter 4 of Matthew and Luke, and so throughout the gospels. While Jesus walked on earth during His ministry, He has never called or given anyone a title as severe as "the devil", with Him referring to the Pharisees and scribes as "offspring of vipers" (Matt. 12:34, 23:33), and to king Herod who wants to kill Him "that fox" (Luke 13:31). The term "the devil" is also used ontologically when Jesus referred called out Judas be to a devil, meaning the term "devil" is implied to be equivalent to Judas. In contrast, when Jesus told Satan to get behind Him in Matthew chapter 18, it was only a functional rebuke, not an equivocal one. The reason why Jesus considers Judas Iscariot to be equivalent to the devil can be found in Luke and John's writings, where both authors wrote that Satan entered into Judas Iscariot (Luke 22:3; John 13:37). Astoundingly, the two authors bear witness to the only occurrence in the Bible where it is explicitly said that Satan himself entered into a person.

In the intimate prayer between the Lord Jesus and the Father in John chapter 17, what the Lord revealed concerning the title and future of Judas Iscariot may be most conclusive to the interpretation that Judas Iscariot is the False Prophet. "When I was with them, I kept them in Your name, which You have given to Me, and I guarded them; and not one of them perished, except the son of perdition, that the Scripture might be fulfilled" (John 17:12). In His prayer to the Father, He was burdened to pray for His apostles and disciples to be preserved, and this was fulfilled when Jesus was with them from the beginning of His ministry up to the day of His crucifixion, only one perished, that is Judas Iscariot when he hanged himself after seeing Jesus was condemned (Matt. 27:3-5). Thus, the reference to Judas Iscariot as "the son of perdition" by Christ undoubtably confirms his eternal fate, as the fulfilment of the scripture is for the False Prophet to be cast into the lake of fire (Rev. 19:20) alongside the Antichrist.

What is most fascinating about the term "the son of perdition" is that it is mentioned only twice in the Bible, the second time in the apostle Paul's second epistle to the Thessalonians on the coming Antichrist. "Let no one deceive you in any way, because it will not come unless the apostasy comes first and the man of lawlessness is revealed, the son of perdition" (2 Thes. 2:3). Here the term "the son of perdition" was given to the Antichrist as the "man of lawlessness", the one who intends to change the law (Dan. 7:25) and to exult himself above all (2 Thes. 2:4, Dan. 11:36). We see that the same term "the son of perdition" used by Christ to address Judas Iscariot was the same term used by Paul to address the Antichrist, implying both are of equal in their status and fate. Making both characters, the Antichrist and the False Prophet the two sons of perdition, which will be fulfilled in Revelation 19:20, when both beasts are seized, and both are cast alive into the lake of fire burning with brimstone.

The Treasurer of the Apostles

Now that we have established the person of the False Prophet to most likely be Judas Iscariot, we can similarly gain a greater understanding of his role with the mark of the beast, as we have with the Antichrist, through looking into their conduct and deeds while they were once alive on the earth. Unsurprisingly, Judas Iscariot was the treasurer of the apostles, meaning he possessed and controlled the purse (John 12:6, 13:29), which the Greek word “γλωσσόκομον” is also translated as “moneybox” or “moneybag”, the modern-day equivalent of the wallet. And the transactions of buying or selling by the apostles and the disciples for the necessities of life were mostly under the control of Judas Iscariot (John 13:29). As the treasurer, Judas was effectively in control of the finances and money of the apostles, a matter which may have displeased the apostle John, when he called out Judas Iscariot for stealing and misusing the funds of the group in writing his gospel (John 12:6).

Therefore, we see that in the gospel of John, Judas Iscariot was in control of the money of the followers of Christ, that is, the apostles and disciples, who will most likely be the coming False Prophet in Revelation, who will be in control of the money of everyone alive on the earth when he comes. The “he” in Revelation 13:16, “and he causes all, the small and the great, and the rich and the poor, and the freemen and the slaves, to be given a mark”, refers to the False Prophet in the context of previous verses from verse 11 onwards. And that no one without the mark would be able to carry out transactions with money, buying or selling, implying the Antichrist and the False Prophet having total control and authority (Rev. 13:12) over the financial and monetary systems of the world at the time of their coming as to permit who can use money to live, and who cannot. To a greater extend, Judas Iscariot, who once was in control of the moneybag of the followers of Christ will be in control the “moneybags” of everyone on earth (Rev. 13:16) when the False Prophet come; just like Caesar Nero, who once persecuted the followers of Christ throughout the Roman Empire will exercise authority over the whole earth to persecute the saints when the Antichrist comes (Rev. 13:7; Dan. 7:21).

Monetary Prowess of the Satanic Triad

The thorough understanding of the persons of the Antichrist and the False Prophet enables us to see their backgrounds, historical context, character, conducts, and deeds to in aiding us to be wise to their schemes and intentions, revealing why a central piece to their operations in the end times, the mark of the beast, carries such economic, monetary, and commercial significance and consequences (Rev. 13:17).

It is no coincidence that the three significant figures behind the mark of the beast were experienced and knowledgeable in money and monetary systems of control. With Satan’s rulership over this world (John 14:30; Eph. 6:12), being a master of commerce (Ezek. 28:4, 16) and a businessman (Ezek. 28:5), Caesar Nero’s authoritative currency controls and influence over the economic activities within the Roman Empire, and Judas Iscariot’s love of money and former position as the treasurer once in control of the moneybag of Christ’s followers. All three characters of the triad possess unique monetary prowess and expertise, setting the foundation for the reality of the economic and monetary consequences of the mark of the beast.

Chapter 4

The Consequences of the Mark

No One is Exempt

The unfortunate reality told by the Bible is that no one person alive on the earth during the great tribulation, the last three and a half years (Rev. 13:5; Dan. 7:25), is exempt from receiving the mark of the beast. It is written that the authority was given to the first beast, the Antichrist, from Satan over every tribe and every people and every tongue and every nation (Rev. 13:7), and power was given to the second beast, the False Prophet, to cause all, the small and great, the rich and poor, the freeman and the slaves to be given them mark (Rev. 13:16). Hence, the Bible makes it very clear that with authority over every tribe, people, tongue, and nation, and over all people, the small, the great, the rich, the poor, the free, and the slave, it is the satanic triad's absolute will to cause everyone still dwelling on the earth during the end times to receive the mark of the beast. With the significance of the mark toward the Antichrist and toward God explained earlier in this chapter through analysing the locations of the mark, let us comprehend the dire consequences of receiving the mark and the diabolical intent of Satan behind this scheme.

Dire Consequences

When Satan, the fallen archangel Lucifer saw God's creation of man, it was on his heart with every evil intent and hatred to destroy mankind by dragging man into the lake of fire to perish alongside himself, because Satan knew that the day he rebelled against God was the day that judgement was pronounced on him to be cast into the lake of fire (Isa. 14:15; Rev. 20:10), but God is patiently waiting to carry out His judgement on Satan together with man (cf. Matt. 8:29; Jude 1:14) similar to a husband waiting for his wife to get ready for a special occasion (cf. Rev. 19:7). Satan knew that the only way to delay the execution of his judgement sentence is to corrupt and destroy man, by injecting sin and death into man, constituting mankind as sinners, forcing God to destroy man Himself because His binding righteousness cannot allow evil and death to exist perpetually in His creation (Rom. 7:24; Psa. 89:14; Isa. 33:14; Heb. 12:29). Therefore, ever since the day man was created, Satan has not ceased his work in tempting (1 Cor. 7:5), accusing (Rev. 12:10), corrupting (Gen. 6:12), and even devouring man (1 Pet. 5:8; Rev. 12:4). Undoubtedly, the diabolic goal of Satan is to ensure as many people as possible met the requirement to perish in the lake of fire, before he is finally cast into it himself. And the mark of the beast is one such requirement that seals the eternal fate of those who receive it.

Therefore, we see why the devil intends to force the mark of the beast upon everyone dwelling on the earth through his left and righthand man, so that all people may be under his possession and worship his authority and image (Rev. 14:9), and in doing so bringing judgement upon themselves. And this is precisely what is warned in the following chapter after revelation of the mark: "If anyone worships the beast and his image and receives a mark on his forehead or on his hand, he also shall drink of the wine of the fury of God, which is mixed undiluted in the cup of His wrath; and he shall be tormented in fire and brimstone before the holy angels and before the Lamb. And the smoke of their tormenting goes up forever and ever; and they have no rest day and night, those who worship the beast and his image, and whoever receives the mark of his name" (Rev. 14:9-11). Oh what a stark warning! It is clear that whoever receives the mark of the beast will be tormented in fire and brimstone eternally. Though the warning is of those that receive the mark and worship the beast, implying two requirements, the act of receiving the mark

willingly may be itself an act of worshipping the beast, as discussed in the significance of the location of the mark on the right hand.

The burning fire and brimstone is confirmed to be the lake of fire in the later chapter, as the Antichrist and the False Prophet, the two “sons of perdition” were seized and cast alive into the lake of fire, which burns with brimstone (Rev. 19:20). Though in Revelation 19:20 the people who have the mark of the beast are not explicitly mentioned to be cast into the lake of fire, it is clear that those who worshipped and received the mark are implied, and this was explicit in chapter 14: anyone who worship the beast and receive the mark shall be tormented in fire and brimstone forever and ever (Rev. 14:10-11). We see that it was never on God’s heart to send people to the lake of fire, as throughout the Bible there are three living characters, and only three living characters explicitly named by God to be cast into the lake of fire (Rev. 19:20, 20:10), the three names being: Satan, the Antichrist (the son of perdition in 2 Thes. 2:3), and the False Prophet (the son of perdition in John 17:12).

What a stark and clear warning the Lord has given to us, and to all of mankind in His word! This word of warning is not to stir up fear or distress, but a warning out of His compassions and love for us in His word to all of humanity of coming, impending, and inevitable schemes and deception of the satanic triad, of the things that will and must take place (Rev. 1:1, 4:1, 22:6) for this age to end, and Christ to return. With the word of God and the prophecies within being faithful and true (Rev. 21:5, 22:6), and the understanding of the consequences behind the mark of the beast, and the satanic triad’s absolute intention to force it upon everyone still dwelling on the earth to cause as many people as possible to perish with them in the lake of fire, let us expose how they intend to carry this scheme out.

The Mark’s Only Incentive

The mark of the beast’s only incentive is for people to regain the ability to use fiat money (or simplified as “money”, so throughout the rest of this chapter), that is, to buy and to sell. It is brutally simple and straightforward, no one may be able to buy or sell except him who has the mark. Revelation 13:17 has been the main burden of the author, as it exposes such a clever, grandiose, and diabolical scheme of the devil, and at the same time grants us the precise starting point to counter this scheme, equipped with the knowledge and intelligence of the enemy’s plans.

It is marvellous that God knows every step and plan of Satan and has unreservedly exposed them to us through His word. In this spiritual warfare, as in any warfare, intelligence on the enemy's stratagems and plans is instrumental to a victorious outcome. Therefore, concerning the mark of the beast, the kernel of the satanic triad’s schemes in the end times, the following has been revealed to us through the scriptures.

The Scheme of the Mark

The rise of the Antichrist: A powerful and strong leader will rise from a gentile region around the Mediterranean Sea (Rev. 13:1), and make a deal with Satan to receive power and authority over the world (Rev. 13:2, 7), mirroring Satan’s same unsuccessful offer to the true Christ in the wilderness (cf. Matt. 4:8-9). This strong man will be killed or brought close to the point of death (Rev. 13:3), most likely through assassination. And he will be healed and be resuscitated from

death (Rev. 13:3&14) as a blatant imitation of Christ's death and resurrection, from then onward he will be known explicitly as the Antichrist (Rev. 13:4).

The intention of the Antichrist: The Antichrist claims to be god and above all objects of worship (2 Thes. 2:4; Dan. 11:36) and desires all to worship him (Rev. 13:8). However, he does not have the means to do so and is limited in his ability (as he still a man), he needs a partner to assist in the execution of his plans.

The rise of the False Prophet: The False Prophet arises from the earth (Rev. 13:11), signifying the land of Israel, and joins the Antichrist to exercises all the Antichrist's authority (Rev. 13:12). This time, power was given to the False Prophet to preform many great outward signs (Rev. 13:13, 15) to deceive all people into worshipping the Antichrist and receive his mark (Rev. 13:14, 16, 19:20).

The design of the mark: Undoubtedly, with all authority over the world, including the banking, financial, and commercial systems, and the expertise and prowess in monetary controllership of each one of the satanic triad, they design the mark with the following purposes:

- A sign of ownership to the Antichrist
- A symbol of worship to the Antichrist
- A visible identification that can immediately single out those not submissive to him
- A right to use money within their controlled monetary system

The intention of the mark: With the mark of the beast being a prerequisite for all people to engage in buying and selling, which is the use of money, those who are oblivious to its grave consequences will be deceived into receiving the mark (Rev. 19:20) just to buy the necessities of life to live. Whilst those who refuse to receive the mark will most likely face socio-economic death, be discriminated against and persecuted, and eventually physical death from hunger or thirst due to the inability to purchase any necessities to live, such as food and utilities.

Satan, being the source of all these schemes, intends to take as many people as possible alongside him into the lake of fire, as warned most clearly and explicitly that anyone with the mark of the beast will suffer in the lake of fire eternally (Rev. 14:9-11). And the mark seems to be permanent and irreversible; the Bible offers no hint or possibility of salvation for those who have received it (cf. Matt. 6:24).

The Right to Use Money

The mark forces a clear choice upon all dwelling on the earth: either conform to the cult of the Antichrist and regain one's ability to use money, or face certain death from deprivation or persecution due to one's inability to use money and being easily identifiable. It will only be a matter of time before everyone alive on earth must decide whether to receive the mark and have the ability to buy food, water, and live life, or to face certain deprivation and persecution.

As noted by the German banker Mayer Rothschild: "permit me to issue and control a nation's money, and I care not who writes the laws", the truth behind this becomes ever clearer in an age of increasing financial and monetary centralisation, where money is the embodiment of status and power, digits on a screen that a financial institution tells you it is yours, rather than the underlying value of its material worth. It was Rothschild's observation that the person who controls the aggregate monetary system (and hence the money) of a nation controls the

livelihood of its citizens; extrapolated further, the person who controls the aggregate monetary system of the world controls the livelihoods of all people of the world (cf. Rev. 13:7). Across all human civilisations, particularly in this day and age, the right for an individual to use money is synonymous to the right for an individual to live. As money is a means of survival through the purchase and selling of necessities, he who takes away your ability to use money takes away your ability to live.

In the early 2020s, during the COVID-19 pandemic, many businesses refused to sell or provide services if people didn't carry proof of vaccination or wear an approved face covering. Regardless of one's beliefs concerning these issues, what is to be highlighted is that there was widespread refusal of service if people didn't comply, a foreshadowing of the foreseeable consequences of the mark of the beast in the future to come. In addition, the migration into a cashless society and the increasing digitalisation of identity and money are eroding and replacing individual sovereignty with convenience. Purchasing goods and services is as simple as stretching out our hand with a tap of the card, and the world of internet banking and payment systems has integrated (or is integrating) facial recognition to unlock access to our bank accounts for greater convenience, a technology our phones already employ. Without the intention of stirring up fear against any technology that has become integral in enabling us to spend and receive money, it can be objectively observed that we are gradually being brought into a time when the mark can be more and more seamlessly integrated into society.

The mark of the beast being a prerequisite to an essential human right to survival, the right to use money, is undoubtedly the mark's ironclad design. To any person unfamiliar with the prophecies of the Bible, they can be easily deceived into receiving the mark as a means to survival (cf. Rev. 19:20) for three and a half years, not knowing that they have received irreversible eternal judgement of the lake of fire upon themselves to perish alongside the beast in eternal perdition (Rev. 14:9-11, 19:20), having received his mark. (It aches the author's heart to write this, but such is the true and faithful word of God given to us, and to a much greater extent, God's heart; therefore He revealed this to us ahead of time, that the people still dwelling on the earth, and even God's chosen, would not be deceived).

Yet, what proves to be mark's ironclad design is also what will prove to be its fatal flaw where we can explore to arrive at its solution. By having only one grave (and seemingly impeccable) incentive for the mark of the beast, Satan made the mistake that would make any experienced engineer shake their head, having a single point of failure in the design of the mark of the beast. Satan went all-in in betting that all forms of money would either be subject to a central authority of control (e.g. fiat currencies) or be rendered useless due to the inherent dangers of being physical (e.g. precious metals) during the end times, where the mark serves as the most visible physical identification to easily target those without the mark.

So then, a solution would be akin to a form of money that exists wholly outside of current systems of the world, cannot be controlled, confiscated, corrupted, or centralised by any entity, is not permissioned to use, ideally digital and not physical, and is accessible globally to anyone without any arbitrary requirements. A medium of exchange that enables people to store value across time and transfer value across space peer-to-peer, that is, to buy and to sell, without the need for permission or requirement from another party.

Chapter 5

The Solution

Throughout all the centuries, a distinctive character of God's people is their unbreakable will to resist the worship of idols. From Moses' anger against the golden calf at Mount Sinai, to Elijah and the seven thousand who have not bowed their knee to Baal, to Daniel and his companions refusing to worship Nebuchadnezzar's golden image, no matter how hopeless and dire the situation seems, God has always provided, will always provide a way out (2 Cor. 1:10).

The Need for a Solution

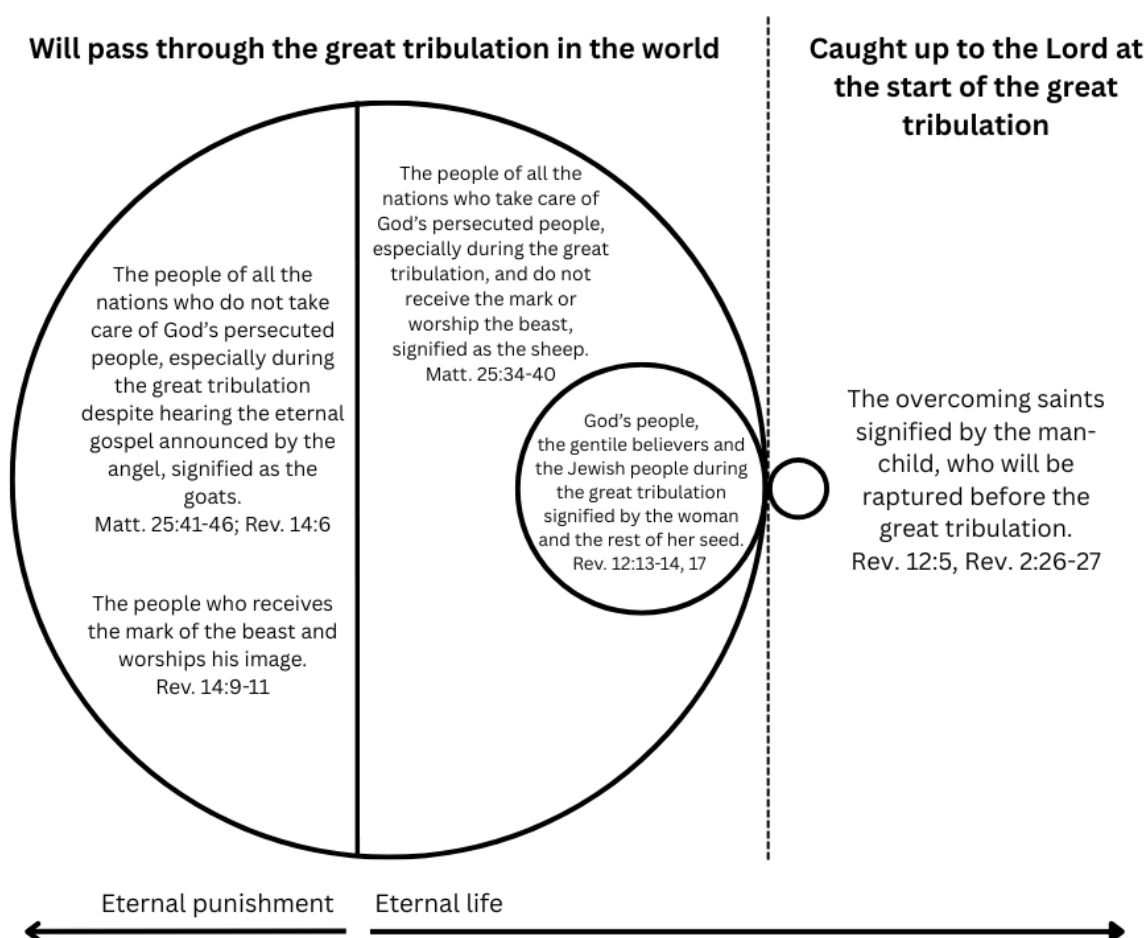
Before we see the potential solution(s) to the mark of the beast for all of humanity, this matter is not to be taken lightly or dismissed, as the burden of the author for the solution is not merely for selfish survival during the great tribulation, which is to simply live on the earth for another three and a half years. No, far be it so, a solution that annuls the mark of the beast (its design and incentive) is able to change the eternal fate of all those still dwelling on earth when the great tribulation begins, and the mark of the beast appears.

It is easy to overlook the severity of the mark of the beast with disingenuous clichés such as salvation as a guarantee to go to heaven, or all Christians will be raptured before the great tribulation. Upon inspecting the evidence found within the Bible, specifically the book of Revelation, we will see that there is a very great need for the survival of God's people and the inhabitants of the earth during the great tribulation, for the people to receive the eternal gospel (Rev. 14:6) and take care of God's suffering people during these three and a half years (Matt. 25:34-40), and for God's people to mature and grow in life under this intensified situation, as the Lord is seeking to gather all His people as those that are mature in life before He returns (Rev. 14:15-16; Matt. 13:3-8). The following is an extract of the footnotes of Revelation 14:14-16 concerning the gathering of the believers near the end of the great tribulation written by Witness Lee:

The harvest of the earth is God's people on earth, the believers in Christ (1 Cor. 3:9). At His first coming to the earth, the Lord sowed Himself into His believers (Matt. 13:3-8, 24). All the believers since that time, who have received Him as the seed of life, have become God's crop on the earth. The first-ripe ones will be reaped as the firstfruits to God before the great tribulation, as indicated in 14:1-5. The majority will ripen with the help of the trials in the great tribulation and will be reaped, raptured, at the end of the great tribulation.

The Greek work for "ripe" literally means to be "dried", to be "dried" of all the earthly water. The suffering of the great tribulation, like the parching sun, will dry up the earthly waters from the believers who are left on the earth in the great tribulation, enabling the believers to ripen. The reaping here in 14:16 will take place after Antichrist forces people to worship him and his image (14:9). Hence, it refers to the rapture of the majority of the believers, who are left on the earth to pass through the great tribulation [13].

Hence, we see that only a minority of the believers will be raptured before the great tribulation, as in the chapter right before the appearance of the Antichrist, the False Prophet, and the mark, Satan as the great dragon (Rev. 12:9) was waging war against a women, who symbolises God's people as the Jews (who keep the commandments of God) and the Christians (who have the testimony of Jesus) in verse 17. We see that the man-child brought forth by the woman is caught up to God and to His throne, before Satan can devour this child, before the three and a half years of the great tribulation (Rev. 12:4-6), signifying the overcoming believers (the man-child) as a minority of all of God's people (the women) will be raptured before the great tribulation, leaving



the majority of God's people still on the earth to pass through the great tribulation for three and a half years (Rev. 12:14). After the man-child was raptured up and the dragon is cast down (Rev. 12:9), Satan will continue to persecute God's people, and to do that, he stood by the sand of the sea summoned the Antichrist (Rev. 12:18, 13:1), setting the stage for the mark of beast beginning Revelation chapter 13.

Additionally, the people dwelling on the earth during the great tribulation who are not yet believers will hear the preaching of the eternal gospel concurrent with the mark of the beast. When Christ returns at the end of the great tribulation (Matt. 24:29-30), He will gather all the people from all the nations before Him, like a shepherd who separates the sheep from the goats, setting the sheep on His right hand and the goats on His left (Matt. 25:31-33). The "sheep" and "goats" are the people of all the nations before the time of Christ's return, with their conduct and actions toward God's persecuted people during this time determining whether they will receive eternal life or eternal punishment (Matt. 25:46). Undoubtably, the people dwelling on the earth

will need a means to survival without receiving the mark of the beast, to be able to somehow buy and sell the necessities for living, and additionally to sustain God's persecuted people; to cloth, to heal, to visit, to shelter, and to provide food and drink to God's persecuted people during the great tribulation (Matt. 25:34-40). It is implied that the people who are the "sheep" who took care of God's people are those who did not receive the mark of the beast, as those who have the mark will share in the fate of the "goats" (Matt. 25:41; Rev. 14:9-11). Therefore, it is implied that the people on the earth will need (or have, because both Matthew chapter 25 and the book of Revelation are written in the past tense) a means of economic survival without the mark of the beast.

There is no middle ground during the great tribulation, all people on earth will face the inevitable and unavoidable choice of submitting to the Antichrist and caring for the Antichrist's interests, or receiving Christ and the gospel, and caring for Christ's people; from their actions and conducts in that time, those who are not for the Lord are against the Lord (Matt. 25:41-46, 12:30). It is clear that the great tribulation is intended for the Christ's believers on the earth to grow and mature in life before Christ's return, and for the trialling of the people of the earth who are yet non-believers to determine if they are willing to receive the gospel (Rev. 14:6) and distinguish those who will side with God from those who will side with the Antichrist (Matt. 25:32-34)

The Requirements for a Solution

Because of the all-inclusive nature and the global reach of the mark over all of humanity (Rev. 13:7, 16-17), any solution to the mark of the beast must ought to be all-inclusive in countering the mark's sole incentive of permissioning the use of money, and be global, available to every tribe and people and tongue and nation, to the small and the great, the rich and the poor, and the freemen and the slaves. Therefore, the solution ought to be permissionless to use, and is universally available, accessible, and recognised by everyone for storing and transacting value; something most similar to gold in terms of its universal function as a store of value and medium of exchange.

Economic Survival & the Utility of Money

To strike at the mark of the beast's only point of failure, we have exposed that the Antichrist's initial rise to power and authority over the whole world will most likely not be through global terror and bloodshed, but through the control of global monetary systems. As Satan, being a master of commerce and business (cf. Ezek. 28:16) will hand over his power and great authority to the Antichrist (Rev. 13:2, 7) over the world and the world's systems (cf. Matt. 4:8-9), inclusive of the banking, financial, commercial, and monetary systems of the world. As such, cleverly and deceitfully disguising the Antichrist as a (charismatic and powerful) strong man who can take over and rule the world without firing a bullet. This is not to say that the Antichrist is peaceful, but instead appears to be only as a pretence, a man skilled in deception and ambiguities (Dan. 8:23-25), peaceful like a nuclear bomb when it is not blowing up. When his true colours are revealed, that man of lawlessness will also be known as the destroyer, Apollyon (Rev. 9:11), and he will do much destroying of the earth and of mankind and wage war against God's people (Rev. 13:7; Dan. 7:7, 8:23-25). It is human nature that we like to follow those we consider charismatic and successful; most certainly, the Antichrist will draw many to follow him even before showing his true colours and identity. What a deceitful yet clever scheme for world domination and setting up the stage for the mark of the beast!

The method of control and authority that enabled the Antichrist to rise to the highest power and authority given from Satan will only be intensified once the great tribulation begins, hence the Antichrist's mark carries such economic and monetary significance and impact over the world (Rev. 13:17). That is, through the Antichrist authoritative control over money, he blatantly takes away the ability for all people on earth to use money unless one receives the mark of the beast. As we all have taken for granted the universal right of the ability to use money, we have seldom, if ever, appreciated the utility of money's function or ever imagined living without money as a medium of exchange. As food for thought, imagine what life would be like living without using a medium of exchange for making economic transactions for a month: what should you take to the market to barter for food? How much of that "what" should you take without a proper unit of account concerning the price? Will the person selling the food accept "what" you are bartering for at the right time and place? What would it look like to pay for petrol or utilities with physical objects for both the buyer and the seller, rather than a single tap of a card or click of a button?

Without the function of a medium of exchange, we quickly find ourselves lining up at the petrol station trying to convince the owner why fish and lemons are just as valuable as cigarettes to trade for petrol. Saifadean Ammous, the author of the 'Bitcoin Standard' and economist from the Austrian school of economics, illustrates best in his book 'The Bitcoin Standard' why barter is not as desirable as many may think:

Barter has always existed in human society and continues to this day, but it is highly impractical and remains only in use in exceptional circumstances, usually involving people with extensive familiarity with one another. In a more sophisticated and larger economy, the opportunity arises for individuals to specialise in the production of more goods and to exchange them with many more people - people with whom they have no personal relationships, strangers with whom it is utterly impractical to keep a running tally of goods, services, and favours.

The problem is deeper than different requirements for different goods, as there are three distinct dimensions to the problem of bartering. First, there is the lack of coincidence in scales: what you want may not be equal in value to what you have and dividing one of them into smaller units may not be practical. Imagine wanting to sell shoes for a house; you cannot buy the house in small pieces each equivalent in value to a pair of shoes, nor does the homeowner want to own all the shoes whose value is equivalent to that of the house. Second, there is the lack of coincidence in time frames: what you want to sell may be perishable but what you want to buy is more durable, making it hard to accumulate enough of your perishable good to exchange for the more durable good at one point in time. It is not easy to accumulate enough apples to be exchanged for a car at once, because they will rot before the deal can be completed. Third, there is the lack of coincidence of locations: you may want to sell a house in one place to buy a house in another location, and (most) houses aren't transportable.

These three problems make direct exchange highly impractical and result in people needing to resort to performing more layers of exchange to satisfy their economic needs. The only way around this is through indirect exchange: you try to find some other good that another person would want and find someone who will exchange it with you for what you want to sell. That

intermediary good is a medium of exchange [in other words, money, recognised by social consensus] [14].

The mark of the beast makes physical transactions (and going out physically in general) dangerous, as one would preferably not want to be in public without the mark of the beast under the Antichrist's government, due to how easily identifiable the mark makes to distinguish who is a loyal subject and who is not. With the punishment being caught without the mark being as severe as beheading (Rev. 20:4), it seems that bartering and all forms of transactions requiring the physical presence of the buyer and seller, such as the use of physical moneys, are altogether not a viable and sustainable solution to the mark of the beast.

Buyers and Sellers

Another point to clarify before arriving at the solution is the emphasis on buying and selling. The key verse of this chapter, Revelation 13:17, says that no one may be able to buy or sell except having the mark of the beast, not just merely unable to buy, or not just merely unable to sell, but both. The explicit mention of both the actions of buying and selling in the same verse reveals that the consequences of the mark do not merely stop at an economic one regarding limits on trades, but in greater detail a monetary one concerning the use of money.

For as long as humans have begun to trade, there have always been ways to limit economic activities through placing certain restrictions and requirements on either the buying or the selling of goods. For example, a food-safety licence may limit the number of shops and restaurants selling certain food and beverages, but consumers do not need a license to dine at a restaurant; therefore, the license is a form of restriction to selling, not buying. On the other hand, a pharmacy is always open during regular business hours, but to be able to purchase certain medications, one must have a doctor's prescription, as a restrictive requirement to buying, not selling. In fact, the imperial seal of the Neronian charagma and guild membership we analysed earlier were examples of requirements that affected either buying or selling, but not conclusively both. In order to definitively and conclusively restrict and control the ability and actions of both buying and selling simultaneously, one must control the underlying thing that anchors buying and selling together as two sides of the same coin: money. I believe with good reasons that the Antichrist will not try to impose restrictions on the buying or selling of every commodity and item and service in order to impede their buying or selling. Rather, by simply controlling money, he is able to all-inclusively have power over the buying and selling of everyone in everything.

Because the use of money as a medium of exchange facilitates the act of buying and selling simultaneously, with money, when one sells, another buys, and when one buys, another sells. One party cannot buy without another party selling. When money exists, buying and selling will always be two sides of the same coin. When using money to buy, or receiving money through a sale, the reciprocal action always occurs. Therefore, most unsurprisingly, to universally force everyone to receive the mark of the beast by universally depriving everyone's ability to buy or sell, the Antichrist achieves this through having full authority and control over money (more specifically, fiat money).

Arriving at a Solution

Intermediaries, Counterparties, and Permission

Money can be simply defined as a medium of exchange used between two or more parties for exchanging value, with the underlying object's monetary properties defining how well this neutral object (e.g. seashell, paper, gold) functions as money, which will be discussed in greater depth in the following chapter. Theoretically, any object can function as money, but not every object is accepted as money. Typically throughout human history, an object emerged to be money through organic social consensus due to its competitive monetary properties above other objects; the best examples are gold and silver, which emerged to function as money across all cultures and civilisations that had the capabilities to obtain them, not through a global decree, but due to their exceptional monetary properties. Throughout human history, many things have served the function of money: most notably gold and silver, but also copper, seashells, stones, salt, cattle, gems, and even toilet paper and cigarettes in certain conditions. People's, and by in large, societies' choices are subjective, and so there is no "right" and "wrong" choice of money. There are, however, consequences behind choices.

Today, fiat money has become synonymous with money, even replacing our concept of money as a whole. Generations of the 20th century grew up to believe money as a piece of paper or plastic issued by the government with a number, and generations after 21st century are growing up to believe money is a string of digital numbers told to us by a financial institution, we have rarely questioned why this particular piece of rectangular paper or this string of digits is worth the value that another party says it to be worth. The problem with money in today's age is that the underlying object that serves the function of money is wholly detached from the creation of God (refer to the list in the prior paragraph), to become subject to adulteration and manipulation by man. Money has become fiat (Latin for by decree, order, or authorisation), or fiat has become money replacing all other forms of moneys in today's times. A medium of exchange that emerged not due to social consensus, but enacted through decree, law, or authority by a person or a governing entity, whose value is dictated by its issuer, and the right to use is integrated upon layers and layers of permission.

The emergence of fiat money (or fiat currencies) in the latter half of the 20th century is an anomaly in human history, a global phenomenon no older than six decades (as of the time of writing), a time not long enough to make up 1% of human history, but long enough to replace our concept of money from something that is "hard" to fiat. Indeed, throughout history kingdoms and empires have decreed and issued their own currencies, but the value of those currencies, such as the Roman Denarius and the Lydian Stater pertains to the base metal; minting the faces of rulers on the coins proves to be no more than an act of regal vanity. If an emperor were to replace the base metal of an empire's coinage from gold to iron, but still forces everyone to accept the original face value of the coin, he would find himself in no small troubles. What differentiates "hard" from fiat is that for a coin with the same base metal and mass, the value of the coin does not change regardless of what number is stamped on it by anyone. For example, if you travel back 2000 years to the Roman Empire and stamp the number "2" on a Denarius silver coin, its value remains the same as any other single Denarius coin. If an item costs two Denarius coins, the merchant would not accept your single Denarius coin with the number "2" on it, he will require two coins for your purchase. However today, if the mint is to take the same two

identical coins and stamp “1” on the first coin and “2” on the second coin, we accept the second coin is worth twice as much in value compared to the first coin.

It was only since the latter half of the 20th century that fiat has persisted and become universal, though it has appeared sporadically and locally in history. The practise and zeitgeist of fiat was pioneered by no other than Caesar Nero, being the first emperor to debase the Roman Empire’s coinage by reducing the silver content of the Denarius while maintaining its face value by decree, shifting the basis of intrinsic economic value from of the silver Denarius from its metal content to the sovereign authority dictated by the emperor. Setting the precedent that the emperor could treat the currency as a flexible tool for policy and personal interest for his successors, and for the monetary authorities of today’s times. By the late 3rd century, the Denarius was less than 5% silver [15]. It was essentially a base-metal coin that the empire forced people to accept at the value of silver, with disastrous consequences for the empire’s economy.

Objectively, the principle of fiat is manipulation and control, it is only with centralisation and authority that the value of something can be fixed and dictated by an authority. Going back to the problem of being unable to buy or sell without the mark of the beast, our current monetary system (or fiat system) has embedded layers of intermediaries, counterparties, and permission into all aspects of storing, transferring, and transacting with money in our daily lives.

The invention and adoption of fiat leads to a slippery slope that erodes away money’s sovereignty and adds more and more layers of permission and trust, beginning first with trusting the value of money would be upheld by its issuer, and then gradually surrendering one’s ownership by entrusting its custody to financial institutions, and then one’s ability to transact from the permission from payment processing intermediaries. The root problem with fiat money is all the trust that’s required to use it. The issuer must be trusted not to debase the currency, and the financial institutions must be trusted to honour our deposits to allow withdrawal and payments upon request. However, the short history of fiat currencies has been one full of breaches of that trust.

The act of trusting counterparties in the storing and transferring of one’s money when the Antichrist takes control over the inhabited earth is analogous to allowing strangers to put their hands around one’s neck and trusting they will not choke one to death when they are coerced, pressured, threatened, or controlled by a greater authoritative figure. This is not to say that intermediaries and counterparties we entrust with the storage and transfer of our money are inherently malicious, but they, like any other human, are equally fallible and susceptible to act against the interests of their fiduciaries when theirs is at risk. Let us have a look through the intermediaries and counterparties involved in today’s typical day-to-day monetary transactions.

Point-of-Sale Merchant Card Payment						
The Government						
Alice	Bank A →	Payment Gateway → (e.g. Stripe, Paypal, Square, Windcave)	Payment Processor → (e.g. Fiserv, Worldpay)	Card Network → (e.g. Visa, Mastercard)	Bank B	Bob

Domestic Bank Transfer				
The Government				
Alice	Bank A →	Clearing House → (e.g. The Federal Reserve, Pay.UK, EBA)	Bank B	Bob

The tables above, in a nutshell, show the typical process for a point-of-sale card payment with a merchant (top table) and a domestic bank transfer (bottom table) and the usual types and numbers of intermediaries/counterparties expected in the processing of each transaction with our current fiat monetary system. Taking Alice as the buyer and Bob as the seller in this economic transaction, in order to prevent both Alice and Bob from engaging in economic transactions with each other, that is, to buy and to sell, only one intermediary is needed to withhold permission to transact for either Alice or Bob in order to prevent Alice from using money and Bob from receiving. In addition, all fiat digital transactions occur in the backdrop of government supervision. Although the government does not directly take part in the transaction process, it possesses the greatest authority and influence over all parties involved in the transaction between Alice and Bob. Simple and effective methods can be requiring banks to freeze or confiscate the deposits of all persons who do not meet an arbitrary requirement (cf. Rev. 13:17). The conclusion is, we need a medium of exchange that can be transacted peer-to-peer, without needing permission and trust from any counterparties.

Prior to the advent of fiat moneys and digitalisation of money, transactions with physical moneys, which were predominantly precious metals, were conducted peer-to-peer, meaning money moved directly from the possession of Alice to Bob, from the buyer to the seller without any intermediaries and counterparties. When Alice goes to a market in Rome, she does not need to take her banker along to shop and ask her banker for permission to use her Denarius coins every time she completes a transaction. Transactions with physical moneys that occur face-to-face are peer-to-peer, and therefore occur on a permissionless and trustless basis (i.e., without the need for permission or trust) as there are no counterparties between the buyer and seller.

Transacting with Physical Moneys	
Physical Threats	
Alice →	Bob

However, the fatal flaw of physical moneys is the fact that they are physical, and subject to threats and risks in the physical realm. Such threats and risks includes, and is not limited to government banning and interventions, such as the American President Franklin D. Roosevelt's Executive Order 6102, which prohibited the possession of gold coins and bullion by U.S. citizens, with penalties being up to 10 years in prison and \$10,000 fine in 1933, or the recall of Denarius coins by Roman mints authorised by Caesar Nero in the emperor's decree to debase the Roman coinage. Authorities could also enforce restrictions on the custody and carrying of physical moneys, as seen across airports and seaports that cap the value of physical precious metals and cash individuals can carry, despite the money being wholly and legally owned by the individual.

Furthermore, users of physical moneys are exposed to the same pitfalls that physical moneys are subject to. For example, the ban and confiscation of gold under the democratic government of President Franklin D. Roosevelt could equally (if not more) likely happen under the Antichrist; the restrictions on the movement of physical moneys could equally (if not more) likely to apply to persons without the mark of the beast, and merchants and service providers might not accept physical moneys at all, or not without some identification or having a physical covering over one's face. And even if one can sustain oneself by conducting economic transactions only with physical moneys, notwithstanding, the dangers of appearing physically in public without the mark of the beast would simply be too grave in a world under the authority of the Antichrist (cf. Rev. 20:4).

Requirements for the Solution

Knowing that the satanic triad intends to deceive all people of the inhabited earth to receive the mark of the beast as a means to their survival through the controlling and granting of the right to use money. The practical solution for the majority of people still on the earth at the time of the great tribulation would be a medium of exchange that is not and cannot be controlled by the government, or by anyone at all, to ensure their own survival without the mark of the beast and to additionally take care of God's persecuted people during that time. Not through violence, but as a sly roundabout way, an exit to the current fiat monetary system that has been setting the stage for the mark of the beast.

Let us crystalise the points we have touched upon earlier concerning the necessary attributes of a medium of exchange that qualifies it to be a potential solution to the mark of the beast, in defeating the sole purpose and point of deception of the mark, the inability to buy or to sell, which is an essential necessity to survival in this age.

Non-physical: Physical moneys require its owner and user to physically store and use. This introduces immense dangers to its users with the risks of confiscation, such as outlawing, theft, or expropriation, and the need to travel physically, given how easily one can be identified with or without the mark of the beast. The threat of physical violence or arrest in a society under the control of the Antichrist simply makes physical moneys too dangerous and unsuitable for use. With malicious intentions, a \$5 hammer in person is more effective than a \$5 billion computer remotely in stopping someone from transacting.

Global: With authority and power over every tribe and people and tongue and nation, they intend to cause all, the small and the great, the rich and the poor, and the freemen and the slaves to receive the mark. Therefore, the medium of exchange must also be global in reach; universally available, accessible, recognised, and non-discriminatory to all, to the rich and the poor, the small and the great, to the people that one likes and the people that one doesn't like. Gold, in this regard, is the undefeated medium of exchange that is universally recognised and, for millennia of human history, the most widely used as money until the 20th century. Frustratingly, gold's only fatal flaw is that it is physical.

Peer-to-Peer (Permissionless): Anyone can send or receive it without asking a central authority or intermediaries for permission. This prevents gatekeepers from blocking transactions. The principle is simple: no gatekeepers to block transactions, so no transactions can be blocked.

Self-custody: A medium of exchange that is custodied and controlled directly by holders rather than custodial intermediaries (e.g. banks and exchanges). If you hold it, others can't freeze it. The shift from decentralised self-custody to centralised custodial intermediaries unsurprisingly parallels the transition from hard to fiat money over the past century. When God ordained precious metals to function as media of exchange for the children of Israel, He also intended for them to be decentralised and self-custodied by individuals and families (cf. Exo. 22:7; Deut. 14:25-26; Prov. 21:20), rather than to be entrusted to centralised financial authorities such as the money changers (John 2:15), who were the precursors to modern bankers.

Seizure resistant: The medium of exchange should be hard to confiscate without the holder's cooperation, as the ability to seize or freeze one's funds will render it unusable for its owner in transacting, regardless of the quantity of funds. Bearer instruments like cash or gold are seizure-resistant if physically hidden, while cryptographic custody resists all forms of seizure unless the cryptographic network is under centralised control or one surrenders access to their funds.

Decentralised: Decentralisation of a (monetary) network means no single party (individual, entity, corporation, or government) can unilaterally decide which transactions are valid and which are not. A medium of exchange of a decentralised network should have no central issuer, no rulers, no gatekeepers, and no gates to keep. Greater decentralisation in a monetary network indicates higher resistance to hostile takeovers and censorship.

Private: For digital media of exchange, privacy is of utmost importance for user safety. For physical moneys, transactions are traceless and any records are kept localised and decentralised. Without privacy, users become targetable. Information from transactions could be easily linked to one's personal identity and sensitive personal information, especially one's location. Given all the attributes above, the utility of the medium of exchange would fall void if the safety of its users could not be guaranteed. Again, \$5 hammer in person beats a \$5 billion computer remotely in this regard.

	Fiat moneys (digital)	Fiat moneys (physical)	Gold (physical & non-fiat)
Non-physical			
Global			
Peer-to-peer			
Permissionless to use			
Self-custody			
Seizure resistant			
Decentralised			
Private			

Assessing each type of money we currently have at our disposal based on these attributes, it becomes clear that each has its own pitfalls that make it and its users vulnerable to economic censorship. Digital fiat moneys exchange one's sovereignty for the convenience of use, while physical moneys, like cash or precious metals, makes it unwieldy and potentially dangerous to use in the context discussed in this chapter. Fiat cash is akin to arcade tokens around the globe, only able to have recognised value and be spent within the jurisdiction of its issuer, while

precious metals, though recognised globally, are highly impractical for individuals to transact globally (over long distances) without involving third parties.

Given the fallibility of the media of exchange we currently have at our disposal, does this mean all hope is lost for the people still dwelling on the earth when the Antichrist comes? Will they have to either receive the mark of the beast or face certain deprivation with no ability to buy or to sell? The answer would be yes, there would be almost no chance for the vast majority of people dwelling on earth to survive for more than three years without the ability to buy or to sell in the 21st century, and it is because of this fact, the satanic triad is scheming to deceive as many people as possible into receiving the mark of the beast (Rev. 19:20) to perish alongside them in the lake of fire.

HOWEVER, if no medium of exchange existed (and continues to exist) as a solution that annuls the mark of the beast at the time of writing, the author would not have picked up the pen and keyboard to write this very book. Before 2008, the author would also have been as clueless as most about the mark of the beast and what people around the world should do to immunise themselves against it. But 2008 saw the genesis of a new medium of exchange that possesses all of the attributes required to be the solution to the mark of the beast. A peaceful roundabout way that took the control of money away from the hands of the government.

Bitcoin: A Peer-to-Peer Electronic Cash System

In 2008, an anonymous individual known by the pseudonym Satoshi Nakamoto published a white paper on a cryptographic peer-to-peer digital cash system called Bitcoin. In this white paper, the unknown creator of Bitcoin established its original and the only intention to function as a purely peer-to-peer digital medium of exchange in a decentralised network that enables transactions to be sent directly from one party to another without going through or needing the permission of an intermediary financial institution.

I've been working on a new electronic cash system that's fully peer-to-peer, with no trusted third party.

– Satoshi Nakamoto, 2008 [1]

Satoshi identified the concern in 2008 that commerce and transactions have come to rely almost exclusively on financial institutions serving as gatekeepers and trusted third parties in the transacting and storing of our money. Although the current system functions well enough for most transactions, it, and by and large its participants, suffer from the inherent weaknesses of the trust-based model. Though, as of now, in developed nations we perceive minimal consequences from such trust-based payment systems, the effect would be critical and immediate if the third parties could no longer be trusted to act in the best interests of the participants of the system.

Prior to the invention of Bitcoin, no mechanism existed to store and transact economic value digitally and without a trusted third party. Culminating from four decades of research and development in cryptography, Satoshi was able to develop a digital payment system based on cryptographic verification instead of trust, allowing any two willing parties to transact directly with each other without the need to trust each other or a third party. By removing these

intermediaries, Satoshi effectively eliminated the centralised checkpoints that authorities traditionally use to monitor and restrict economic transactions.

The potential weaponisation of such centralised access is vividly illustrated in the prophetic word of Revelation chapter 13, which portrays the future in which those who do not comply with receiving the mark of the beast are excluded from economic activities essential to survival in today's age. In contemporary terms, it starkly warns of the ability of centralised financial and political institutions to deny individuals access to financial services. The practical consequences of such exclusion could not be more emphasised: without the ability and means to transact, people across the globe risk losing access to essential goods and services, forcing those ignorant of the mark's most grievous consequences into receiving it.

Against this backdrop, we have come to know that a solution is much needed for the majority of people still dwelling on the earth at the appearing of the Antichrist; a monetary system that is wholly outside, indifferent, and immune to authority and control, a medium of exchange bypassing financial institutions and systems and rendering the mark's design of economic coercion useless by ensuring the right and freedom to store and transact value. As the power of the mark lies in its ability to prevent, censor, and control economic activities, so too does the power of Bitcoin lie in its inability to do the same. Because Bitcoin as a medium of exchange is borderless, permissionless, and resistant to censorship and control, it fundamentally undermines the power dynamics required for the mark of the beast to function. By providing a parallel, globally available monetary system that anyone can access anytime, and that cannot be coerced, controlled, confiscated, or turned off, Bitcoin offers a permanent and voluntary opt-out from a system designed to enforce total economic compliance.

Permissionless and decentralised networks are difficult to take over or shut down universally, and the ability to hold and transfer value without intermediaries means preventing transactions requires physical coercive access to the parties of the transaction rather than merely an administrative order to an intermediary. As a result, the mark of the beast loses its incentive and leverage; if people can transact freely outside of state or institutionally controlled rails, then denying access to those rails will not prevent one from transacting and offers little to no incentive for receiving the mark of the beast.

As peer-to-peer networks wholly outside the operations and control of modern financial, monetary, and political systems, Bitcoin (and similar decentralised networks) constitute a genuine countermeasure and escape from state coercion and economic exclusion. The author recognises that technology alone cannot unilaterally resolve the full set of complex political, social, and legal dynamics that underlie the global situation during the Antichrist's final three-and-a-half-year reign, and the efficacy of an alternative monetary network such as Bitcoin (or any technology in general) depends on sufficient adoption and user education. Nonetheless, Bitcoin remains the sharpest tool in humanity's shed for peacefully resisting any and all forms of financial and economic coercion, control, or censorship destined to take place in the world at the coming of the Antichrist and the mark of the beast.

Chapter 6

Understanding Money

Portions of this chapter have been adapted, rewritten, or expanded from the following works: The Bullish Case for Bitcoin by Vijay Boyapati (2021), The Bitcoin Standard by Saifedean Ammous (2018), and Layered Money by Nik Bhatia (2021). The author is grateful for their foundational research and explanation, which have propelled the author's understanding of money and Bitcoin and have helped inform the ideas presented in the chapter by piecing together and further expounding on their writings.

Understanding Bitcoin requires asking a simple question that turns out to be a very complicated one to answer. That simple question is “What is money”? In essence, Bitcoin is simple: it is a medium that holds value in a trustless and permissionless way across time and space, which no other party can steal, dilute, inflate, control, confiscate, expropriate, or coerce. But how do we arrive at this conclusion? What even is a dollar? And why do groups of unelected economists get to decree that some pieces of papers are more valuable than others? There are many questions yet to be answered.

Throughout human history, many things have served the function of money. Most notably being gold and silver, but also copper, seashells, glass beads, large stones, salt, cattle, government paper, and even alcohol, toilet paper, and cigarettes in particular cases and times. People's choices are subjective, and there is no definitively right or wrong choice to money. But there are, however, latent consequences behind people's choice of money throughout civilisations. Most people who live to average life expectancy spend roughly 90,000 hours in their lifetimes working for money [16], but unfortunately, very few take the time to understand what money really is.

Genesis

When God created the world and all its fullness, He welcomed humanity to a world of abundance and all-sufficiency, to live a life trusting and depending on Him as His universal counterpart. But man fell, we decided to sever our dependence on God, and rule the world according to our knowledge and judgment of good and evil. And in the process of man's fall, trust was lost between man and God (Gen. 3:8) and between man and man (Gen. 3:12, 4:8), and the abundance of the earth was taken away (Gen. 3:17).

In a world of scarcity and a lack of trust, to survive we needed to toil, we needed to trade, but we have no trust in each other. Exchanging the goods and services as the fruits of our labour face to face and good for good through bartering was only feasible in small communities, at few places, at few times, for few goods. As mankind filled the earth and expanded our population and communities, we needed a trusted medium of exchange to trade the fruits of our labour for the fruits of others' labour in more places, at more times, for more goods. Man needed something that stored and preserved value in consensus among its users to be a medium of exchange, so that he could work, trade, eat, live, and multiply. This is how the concept of money came into the world: a medium of exchange for value.

Before elucidating the intricacies of what makes money “money”, great emphasis should be put on differentiating the concept of money from the underlying object used as money. The Lord told

us that it is the love of money that is evil (1 Tim. 6:10), and the concept of money that will be abolished in the coming age (Luke 16:11), but things used as money in this age like gold, silver, precious minerals, and paper will still exist into the next age after the Lord returns.

Let's consider gold as one such underlying object used as money. In a story about a greedy king told by the Greeks, King Midas foolishly asked that everything he touched turn to gold, and to him it was granted. At first, he rejoiced as objects transformed into gold, making him unimaginably wealthy. But soon, he realised this curse, his food, drink, and even his beloved daughter turned to gold at his touch. Starving and grief-stricken, he begged that his wish could be reversed.

Hence, we see that money is not the underlying object, but rather its monetary value (or purchasing power in economic terms), agreed upon from the consensus of its users. Therefore, in reality, nobody wants only gold; instead, we want the value gold is able to hold and store, to be used for future transactions. As told in the story of Midas, if one were only to have gold and nothing else, that person would become very miserable very quickly.

Economic Energy

Key words

- **Types/Forms of money:** *Different things that humans consider to be money, e.g. gold, silver, fiat currency, and bitcoin.*
- **Fiat currency:** *Money issued by a government, whose value and supply is controlled by an central authority, commonly referred to as fiat.*
- **Monetary value:** *The value of goods and services that a type of money can be exchanged for; frequently used as the aggregate value of all of one type of money.*
- **Purchasing power:** *Interchangeable with monetary value; frequently used as the monetary value of one type of money on a unit basis, e.g. per \$100.*

Money (not the underlying object, but the value it holds) is the representation of the time and energy required to produce goods and services. It can also be viewed as value, as stored economic energy. Since the formation of early human communities to modern civilisations, we work for money; hence, your money is the stored units of the time and energy you expended and worked for.

Money you earned = Your expended time + Your expended energy

Thinking of money's value as equivalent economic energy, we can transform it into chemical potential energy as food for our body, convert it into heat and electrical energy to heat and power our homes, and exchange it for kinetic energy as we fuel our cars or hop on aeroplanes. The more economic energy we possess, the greater the quantity of other forms of energy we can convert into and utilise. With more money, I can buy more steaks for dinner, or afford to travel by plane instead of walking on foot to another city. Naturally, being a form of energy, it too shall then obey the laws of thermodynamics established at the creation of the universe (Job 38:33).

The First Law – Energy cannot be created or destroyed, only transferred.

Man himself cannot create nor destroy energy; this law also holds true for economic energy, as the total aggregate monetary value in an economy. If a central bank decides to print money (in

this case, fiat money) and double the supply of money in an economy overnight whilst the goods and services of that economy remain constant, the purchasing power of that fiat money is expected to halve (or the price of those goods and services to double). Aggregate monetary value, hence, the total economic energy within the economy, remains unchanged.

Another example, if I were to wave a magical wand and half of the gold in the world vanishes, we can expect the price of gold to double immediately. Again, the total monetary value of gold remains unchanged, the total economic energy of the aggregated gold supply remains constant.

Hence, the first law of the conservation of energy elucidates that “free money” from printing money by banks out of thin air isn’t free, because energy cannot be created from nothing; the purchasing power of every holder of that currency must decrease proportionally to the amount of new money created. By printing money, the system permanently and covertly transfers a portion of the economic energy from everyone else’s current holdings of that money into the newly created supply, being the most significant (but not the only) cause of the loss of purchasing power of fiat currencies, or inflation as commonly known.

The Second Law – The total entropy of a system always increases over time. Energy transformations are never 100% efficient.

Due to entropy, there is always inefficiency, dispersion, and degradation of every form of energy over a long enough period of time. Monetary value will always tend to zero, as the underlying object viewed as money degrades over time due to entropy. The copper coin will rust, the silver will lose its shine, the paper will decompose, and the plastic will fade.

Without accounting for the cost a central entity imposes on centralised fiat currency through inflation and taxation, the dispersion of economic energy will continuously incur costs from the maintenance of the underlying object used as money (storage, security, management fees). This elucidates that no one form of money can maintain 100% of its value forever (James 5:3), with the costs of entropy defining the useful life of each type of money.

The Third Law – As the energy of a system approaches absolute zero (non-existence), the entropy approaches a constant minimum.

The third law of thermodynamics shows it’s impossible to achieve a state of perfect economic efficiency (zero waste, zero friction, zero inefficiency, no entropy) with money as stored economic energy. As long as money is continued to be used, a state of maximum efficiency in an economy can never be achieved.

Therefore, achieving a maximally efficient economy (entropy approaches a minimum) requires the complete abolition of money (energy approaches absolute zero). Hence, we now see why money was not in God’s perfect will, and the concept of money emerged wholly through man; the concept of money for the transaction of monetary value is inefficient in a perfect world.

This fascinatingly leads us back to the world of abundance that God had created at the end of the sixth day of creation in Genesis chapter two, and the world to come in the next age as the restoration and enlargement of the Garden of Eden (Rev. 22:1-2), where man depends on God and fully trusts in each other, there is no money, only abundance and sufficiency. A world where he who has much had no excess, and he who gathered little had no lack (2 Cor. 8:15). A world where we do not need to account for the monetary value of transactions, because we can fully trust and rely on each other as God’s children. A world where we always give out and receive

freely from each other, because we know that God loves a cheerful giver (2 Cor. 9:7), and He Himself will always provide.

The Evolution of Money

Key words

- **Monetary properties:** *Various specific unique properties attributable to the underlying object used as money; the strengths and weaknesses of each property influence the pace of its monetisation, and its quality to function as money.*

There is an obsession in modern monetary economics with the medium of exchange role of money. In the 20th century, states have monopolised the issuance of money through central banking and continually undermined its use as a store of value, fostering a false belief that money is only defined as a medium of exchange. The steps of a money's monetisation and dual identity as a store of value and medium of exchange is analogous to the construction of a skyscraper, with a good's store of value capability being the skyscraper's foundation and medium of exchange use cases being its stories.

To build the skyscraper upwards, it must have a firm foundation downwards. Without a firm foundation, the skyscraper would be insecure and unsafe, rendering additional stories useless and hazardous to utilise, regardless of how well designed, decorated, or furnished they are. On the other hand, without constructing any additional stories upon the foundation, the skyscraper would be very unspectacular and not function to its full potential. Hence, both the foundation and the stories of the skyscraper are crucial for its existence and function. When people view the skyscraper, their attention is drawn to its iconic architecture and vibrant night lights. However, for its architecture and functions of hosting offices, hotels, recreation centres and more to be possible, it unquestionably must first have a firm foundation into the earth.

The emphasis on money's characteristics of being a medium of exchange without considering the properties that enable it to store value, is likened to building upwards without laying a foundation. Without any value and the durability thereof, any use cases built on top is void. Money has always evolved in stages, with the store of value role preceding the medium of exchange role, being a foundation for its function [17].

The 4-Stage Evolution of Money

1. **Collectible:** In the very first stage of its evolution, money will be demanded solely based on its peculiar properties, such as its scarcity and shininess. Shells, beads, and gold were all collectibles before later transitioning to the more familiar roles of money.
 - Notable monetary properties: Scarce, durable
2. **Store of value:** The ability to hold value over time. Once it is demanded by enough people for its peculiarities, money will be recognised as a means of storing and preserving value over time. As a good becomes more widely recognised as a suitable store of value from consensus, the value it holds will be maintained, and even appreciate, as more people demand it for this purpose.

- Notable monetary properties: Scarce, durable, portable, established history, censorship resistant
3. **Medium of exchange:** The ability to transfer value across space. When money is fully established as a store of value, its purchasing power will stabilise. Having stabilised in purchasing power, the opportunity cost of using money to complete trades will diminish to a level suitable for use as a medium of exchange. Unique monetary properties will allow money to transfer value across space. Once at this stage, the underlying object will commonly be known as “money”.
- Notable monetary properties: Portable, divisible, verifiable, established history
4. **Unit of account:** When money is widely used as a medium of exchange, goods will be priced in terms of it. For example, the exchange ratio against money will be available and fixed for most goods. For example, \$5 for a cup of coffee today, tomorrow, and next week, not fluctuating like \$4.96 today and \$5.03 tomorrow.
- Notable monetary properties: Portable, divisible, verifiable, fungible, established history

A type of money that is not yet a unit of account may be thought of as being “partly monetised”. Today gold fills such a role, serving as a store of value but having been stripped of its medium of exchange and unit of account roles by government intervention. It is also possible that one type of money fills the role of medium of exchange while another fills the other roles. This is typically true in countries with weaker economies, such as Argentina or Zimbabwe, where the local fiat currency is used for daily transactions across space, but no one will want to store their savings in their local currency for storing value over time.

In the United States of America, the dollar seamlessly serves the three functions of money: providing a medium of exchange, a unit for measuring the cost of goods, and an asset where value can be stored. In Argentina, on the other hand, while the peso was used as a medium of exchange for daily purchases of goods, no one used it as a store of value. Keeping savings in the peso was equivalent to throwing away money. So people exchanged any pesos they wanted to save for dollars, which kept their value better than the peso. Because the peso was so volatile, people usually remembered prices in dollars, which provided a more reliable unit of measure over time.

Bitcoin is currently transitioning from the second stage (store of value) of monetisation to the third stage (medium of exchange). It will likely take several years for Bitcoin to transition from an incipient store of value to a recognised medium of exchange. It is striking to note that the same transition took many centuries for gold. No one alive has seen the real-time monetisation of a good as is taking place with Bitcoin at such an accelerated pace [17].

This now begs the question, what attributes of the underlying object make humans want to attribute value to it? And enable it to gradually evolve in the four-stage monetisation process?

Monetary Properties

When stores of value compete with each other, it is the specific properties of the good that allow it to outcompete another good at the margin and increase demand for it over time. While many goods have been used as stores of value or “proto-money”, certain properties emerged that were particularly demanded, allowing moneys with these attributes to outcompete other moneys and evolve through the four-stage monetisation process. Such properties are:

- **Durability:** The good must not be perishable or easily destroyed. Thus, wheat or 4-leaf clover is not an ideal store of value.
- **Portability:** The good must be easy to transport and store, making it possible to secure it against loss or theft and allowing it to facilitate long-distance trade, minimising transaction costs. A cow is thus less ideal than a gold bracelet.
- **Fungibility:** One specimen of the good should be interchangeable with another of equal quantity. For example, gold can be cut, melted, moulded, and formed into various shapes and sizes, but its properties remain the same, because the gold atoms remain the same. Thus, gold is better than diamonds, which are irregular in shape and quality.
- **Verifiability:** The good must be easy to quickly identify and verify as authentic. Easy verification increases the confidence of its recipient in trade and increases the likelihood that a trade will be completed.
- **Divisibility:** The good must be easy to subdivide. While this attribute was less important in early societies where trade was infrequent, it became more important with the exponential growth in the frequency and velocity of trade.
- **Scarcity:** The good must not be abundant or easy to either obtain or produce in quantity. Scarcity is perhaps the most important attribute of a store of value, as it taps into the innate human desire to collect that which is rare. It is the primary source of the original value of the store of value.
- **Established history** (trust & adoption): The longer the good is perceived to have been valuable by society, the greater its appeal as a store of value. A long-established store of value will be hard to displace by a new upstart money.
- **Censorship-resistance:** A new attribute of money, which has become increasingly important in our modern, digital society with pervasive surveillance and monopolised control of money, is censorship-resistance. That is, how difficult is it for another party, such as a bank or a state, to prevent the owner of the good from keeping and using it [17]. Any type of money, regardless of how excellent the previous attributes are, is worthless if the government simply decides it is no longer yours, a critical attribute as discussed in the in earlier chapters.

Before beginning this chapter, have you ever wondered, why did gold come out on top in its monetisation against diamonds? If my teeth are very scarce, why aren't they worth millions each? Just some food for thought. Well, by accessing the monetary properties of things, we can determine if our candidate will become an ideal money.

Knowing the monetary properties of underlying objects really illustrates why some things are money and why some are not, why gold outcompeted diamonds, why the average lifespan of fiat currencies beginning since the 20th century was only 27 years [18], and why my teeth will never be considered as money despite their rarity.

Monetary Properties of Monies the 21st century					
	Bitcoin	Gold	Diamond	Fiat Money	My Teeth
Durable	A+	A+	A	C	B
Portable	A+	C	B	A	B
Fungible	A+	A	F	A	F
Verifiable	A+	C	C	A	F
Divisible	A+	A	F	A	F
Scarce	A+	A+	A	F	A+
Established history	C	A+	A	B	F
Censorship resistant	A+	C	C	F	F

In a very simple way, monetary properties of things give rise to various types of money, and the quality of monetary properties each type of money possesses determines the ability to advance and the pace of advancement of that money's four-stage monetisation, from a collectible to an unit of account. Monetary properties of things also gauge that type of money's ability to store and transfer economic energy (in other words, value). A good with better monetary properties tends to better store and transfer economic energy, thus people tend to park more of their economic energy in that good, further accelerating its monetisation, growth, and adoption.

	Key Monetary Properties
Store of value	Durability, verifiability, scarcity, established history, censorship resistance
Transfer of value	Portability, divisibility, fungibility, verifiability

Monetary Properties of Bitcoin

Now we have arrived at the understanding that:

- Money is not the underlying object itself, but is its monetary value that we attribute to it; the underlying object often has little to no utility value.
- Money functions as a store of value and a medium for the storage and transfer of economic energy across space and time.
- Money is defined by the monetary properties of the underlying object.
- Monies typically evolve through four stages of monetisation, and can devolve (demonetise) when better forms of money emerge.

Now we can answer the question, "What is Bitcoin"? In the simplest way, Bitcoin is a type of money, and its monetary properties rate it subjectively as the apex money of the 21st century. In

fact, the question “what is Bitcoin” is equally valid as “what is gold”. Digging into the finest details of gold’s atomic structure, electron configuration, and electronegativity of this yellow metal can never explain why gold has value as the oldest and most recognised money in the world. However, by understanding the concept of money and accessing its monetary properties, we will be able to determine whether any good can function as money and assess its capacity as a medium for storing and transferring economic energy.

It sounds too good to be true that Bitcoin achieves an almost perfect score across all monetary properties. Let us objectively and more closely examine the attributes of Bitcoin that define its monetary properties.

Durability: Bitcoin, being the first truly intangible, neutral, and decentralised money in the world, does not suffer from the entropic degradation that all tangible moneys have. It is unaffected by the problems physical money have, like rust, maintenance, obsolescence, accident, theft, or natural disasters; it is unaffected by the problems digital currencies have, like inflation, taxation, and politics; it is unaffected by the problems of physical assets, like rates tax, rent control, law, tenants, leaky roof, insurance, crime, decay, regulation, and more. All of the listed items and more, are elements of entropy in the second law of thermodynamics that naturally erode the economic energy stored within goods, reducing their durability.

Bitcoin, on the other hand, represents a digital transformation of money as pure economic energy; its intangible nature makes it immune to the entropy all physical moneys (or for that matter, all physical things) suffer from. And itself requires no cost of maintenance to possess or carry.

Portability: Bitcoin is the most portable store of value ever used by man. Private keys representing any value of bitcoins, from a single cent to millions of dollars, can be stored on a tiny USB device and easily carried anywhere. Furthermore, equally valuable sums can be transmitted between people on opposite ends of the earth near instantly with final settlement. And finally, once you commit your private key to memory, you now carry that amount of bitcoins in your brain wherever you go, known commonly as “brain wallet”. In a sense, Bitcoin enables our brain to be our bank; it is a money that empowers everyone to be their own bank, and by nature, a money available to everyone by birth.

Fungibility: As physical money, gold provides the standard for fungibility. When melted down, an ounce of gold is indistinguishable from any other ounce. Bitcoins are fungible in the network, meaning that every bitcoin, and every fraction of a bitcoin of the same quantity, is of also of the same quality and value on the Bitcoin network.

Verifiability: In the 21st century, contrary to the findings of the alchemists, gold is no longer immune to being counterfeited. Sophisticated criminals have used gold-plated tungsten as a way of fooling gold investors into paying for fake gold. Bitcoins, on the other hand, can be verified with mathematical certainty. Using cryptography, the owner of a bitcoin can publicly prove they own the bitcoin on the blockchain. It is simply impossible to forge bitcoins on the blockchain given the rapid growth of the network and the energy used to secure the network. The Bitcoin network itself is updated and audited every ten minutes on average by tens of thousands of globally decentralised nodes (run by voluntary node operators) to settle current transactions and confirm all past transactions of the network.

Divisibility: One bitcoin can be divided down to a hundred millionths ($1/100000000$) of a unit, known as one satoshi (or Sat), as the smallest base unit, and transmitted at such infinitesimal amounts. Fiat currencies are typically divisible down to pocket change, which has little purchasing power, making fiat currencies divisible enough in practice. Gold, while physically divisible, is immensely energy-consuming and thus highly impractical for day-to-day transactions.

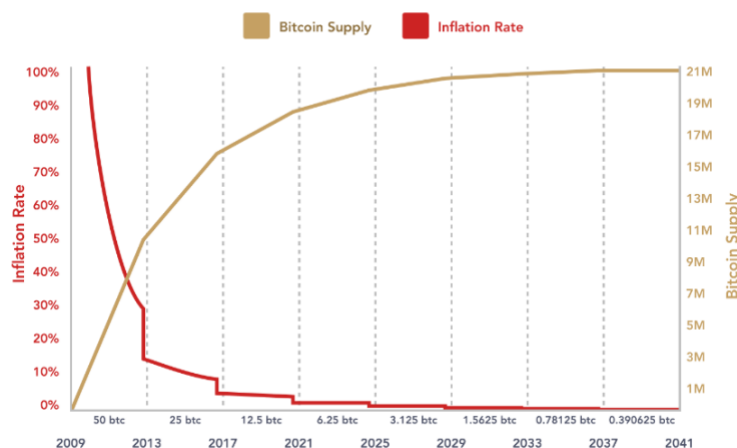
Scarcity: The attribute that most clearly distinguishes Bitcoin from other monies is its predetermined absolute scarcity. By design, at most, 21 million bitcoins can ever be created. This gives us a known percentage of the total possible supply when one holds bitcoins. For instance, an owner of 21 bitcoins would know with absolute certainty that they hold 0.0001% of the aggregate supply. The same cannot be said of fiat currencies or precious metals, where their supply is scarce relatively, and the limit to their aggregate supply is still unknown. Despite being digital, Bitcoin is designed to provide absolute scarcity, which is why it has the

Gold production, 1815 to 2015

Annual gold production, measured in metric tons per year.



Bitcoin Issuance Schedule



potential to be such an effective form of money. There will only ever be 21 million bitcoins, and 21 million is a scarily small number in relative and absolute terms. The Federal Reserve (central bank of the U.S.) created \$100 billion dollars within just a week (4762 times the figure of dollars to Bitcoin in one week), with the click of a button. To provide a broader context, the Federal Reserve, the Bank of Japan, and the European Central Bank have collectively created north of \$17 trillion (\$17,000,000,000,000) dollars in new money in the decade from 2008 to 2018 alone [17]. At the cost of almost nothing.

Gold, while remaining quite scarce through history, is not immune to increases in supply. If it were ever the case that a new method of mining or acquiring gold became economic, the supply of gold could rise dramatically (cf. 2 Chron. 1:15). Bitcoin is the only commodity whose supply cannot increase when demand increases, compared to gold, where mining capacity can be expanded. Consider the annual production of gold (in blue) and the figure of total bitcoin supply (in yellow).

Established history (trust & adoption): No monetary good has a history as long and storied as gold, which has been valued for as long as human civilisation has existed. Coins minted in the distant days of antiquity still maintain significant value today. The same cannot be said of fiat

currencies, which are a relatively recent anomaly of history. From their inception, fiat currencies have had an universal tendency toward eventual worthlessness. The use of “free” money printing as an insidious means of invisibly taxing a citizenry has been a temptation that few states in history have been able to resist. If the 20th century, in which fiat monies came to dominate the global monetary order, established any economic truth, it is that fiat money cannot be trusted to maintain its value over the long or even medium term.

Bitcoin, despite its short existence, has weathered enough trials in the market that there is a high likelihood it will not vanish any time soon. Bitcoin is currently undergoing rapid monetisation, a phenomenon never witnessed before in history for any money. It will likely be several years before Bitcoin transitions from being an incipient store of value to being a medium of exchange.

Censorship-resistance: Bitcoin’s design and engineering meant no single entity (governments, corporations, or individuals) can block, reverse, or arbitrarily restrict valid transactions made with bitcoins. Bitcoin operates on a global, permissionless peer-to-peer network with tens of thousands of nodes and miners securing, protecting, and auditing the network. No central authority controls transaction inclusion. The Bitcoin network is a protocol of rules without rulers. Every node independently verifies all transactions and blocks against Bitcoin’s consensus rules. Invalid transactions are rejected automatically. No one node can force others to accept invalid data or block valid data. Anyone can run a node, broadcast a transaction, or become a miner without approval. There are no gatekeepers, and no gates to breach.

This property ensures Bitcoin remains a neutral, borderless, decentralised, and peer-to-peer monetary system. Users cannot be deplatformed or prevented from transacting based on political views, geography, beliefs, or any arbitrary criteria or requirements (Rev. 13:17), offering significant financial sovereignty and resistance against authoritarian control and coercion, which is inevitable near the end of this age.

The Recovery of Gold in the Digital Age

For close to 6000 years, gold has been the best form of money used by man for trading, exchanging, transacting, and storing economic energy; as a store of value, as a medium of exchange, and gradually as a unit of account. Like every other metal in the periodic table, it was created by God and given for a special purpose as a precious metal for man to use as a medium that can store and exchange value. In fact, the phrase “sound money” originated from the unique sound pure gold coins make when dropped on hard surfaces. To verify their authenticity and quantity with brevity, gold coins were dropped to measure their “soundness” against another golden coin with a known quantity and quality.

Let us reconsider the monetary properties of gold prior to our modern times, a typical time in most of man’s history, such as when the children of Israel were living in the land of Canaan as detailed in the Chronicles of the Bible.

	Gold	Gold in the 21 st century
Durable	A+	A+
Portable	C	C
Fungible	A	A

Verifiable	A+	C
Divisible	A	A
Scarce	A+	A+
Established history	A+	A+
Censorship resistant	A+	C

Certain monetary properties of gold have drastically diminished in the modern world. As civilisations expanded to the ends of the earth, trading changed from local and communal to global and long-distance, drastically diminishing its portability. Though technological advancements will never enable man to create gold as was the dreams of the medieval alchemists, it has given man many sophisticated methods to counterfeit gold; examples being under alloying or gold-plated tungsten bullions.



Through the gradual growth and development of civilisation, societies, nation states, and economies toward the 21st century, the economies of scale for gold inevitably led to its centralisation due to its physical attributes. As of today, almost half of the gold ever mined is locked up and stored away in underground bunkers in secrecy, rather than circulating in the economy as money [14]. The creation of modern banking has severed the use of gold as a medium of exchange and centralised its control in the hands of a few banking institutions, which are under the control of their respective governments.

By the 19th century, with the development if modern banking and the improvement in methods of communication, individuals could transact with paper money and checks backed by gold in the treasuries of their banks and central banks. This made gold-backed transactions possible at any size and scale, thus obviating the need for silver's monetary role... It's tragic flaw, however, was that by centralizing the gold behind the iron bars and vaults of banks, and later central banks, it made it possible for banks and governments to increase the supply of money beyond the quantity of gold they held, gradually and implicitly shifting people's perception of value from gold itself to the trust of governments' promise that their issued paper is backed by an equal value of gold.

Since the beginning of the 20th century, the engineering of the modern banking system has gradually and unnaturally demonetised gold (not of its own will) from a decentralised neutral money to a centralised financial asset. A century ago, if you were living in a developed Western nation in North America or Europe and wanted to store gold at a bank, the only institutions at which your gold would still be there after a century were the Bank of England in London, or banks in Switzerland; everywhere else gold was stored, would've been lost due to theft, confiscation

(i.e. Executive Order 6102) or war. Because of its vulnerability to centralisation and confiscation, gold's censorship resistance has been significantly diminished.

Had government fiat been a superior store of value across all types of moneys, it would not need government legal tender laws to enforce it, nor would governments worldwide have had to confiscate large quantities of gold and continue to hold them in their central bank reserves. The fact that central banks continue to hold onto their gold, and have even started increasing their gold reserves, testifies to the confidence they have in their own currencies in the long term [14].

Tragically, even for the best form of money as man's disposal, being the most established, the most durable, the scarcest, and the global form of physical money recognised and accepted universally, it still suffers from:

<i>Being counterfeited</i>	<i>Being not easily divisible</i>
<i>Being centralised</i>	<i>Being not easily verifiable</i>
<i>Being confiscated</i>	<i>Being not well portable</i>
<i>Being censored</i>	<i>Being too unwieldy</i>

With central banks' monopoly position and restrictions on gold ownership and the enforcement of fiat currency by the law across all nations around the globe, never again would gold return to being the world's homogeneous currency. The introduction of Bitcoin, a currency transcending national borders and existing outside the realm of governmental control, offers an intriguing possibility for the emergence of a new type of money. In a way, a recovery of money akin to gold was much needed after the gradual devolution of money since the departure of the gold standard in 1971. This leads us to the question: without changing the intrinsic monetary properties of gold, based on gold's fatal weaknesses, what can we do to recover it? We can make gold better to preserve value as a store of value by:

- Making gold decentralised by giving its users across the globe, on a voluntary basis, a public and digital record and copy of the network.
- Making gold impossible to counterfeit by auditing every existing atom in circulation and every transaction made periodically.
- Making gold censorship resistant by removing all intermediaries, making transacting permissionless and peer-to-peer.

We can make gold easier to transact as a medium of exchange by:

- Making gold weightless.
- Making gold teleportable to the recipient.
- Making gold easily subdivisible at any time when needed.
- Making gold transparent and safer to use.
- Making gold more portable by giving it the ability to be stored in your mind.

This is where Bitcoin steps into the frame. The point of near-perfection is approached when nothing remains to be taken away to improve it. How was Bitcoin engineered? It was engineered such that all the fatal flaws of every type of money were removed, and all the positive attributes were retained. It is akin to refining gold: the more impurities and dross are removed, the more condensed, pure, and valuable the remaining parts become. Bitcoin's monetary purity makes its

purpose simple: a vessel that stores and transfers economic energy in a trustless and permissionless way across time and space, in a way that is uncontrollable and unstoppable by any single entity.

The idea of keeping all the upsides and removing all the downsides of gold as money was no novel concept, in fact, this was the idea of Satoshi Nakamoto, the creator of Bitcoin, who portrayed this metaphorical idea of a “digital gold”. In a sense, “digital gold” marks the digital transformation of a store of economic energy. A recovery of gold that God intended it to be used as money for man when He permitted the existence of money, lost through the centralisation and restrictions of its ownership enforced by the monetary authorities of this world.

satoshi
Founder
Sr. Member


Re: Bitcoin does NOT violate Mises' Regression Theorem
August 27, 2010, 05:32:07 PM
 Merited by mindrust (2), BlackHatCoiner (2), Gyrsur (1), Husna QA (1), solosequenosenada (1), RainbowKun (1)
[quote](#) #10

Activity: 364
Merit: 4756

[Ignore](#)

As a thought experiment, imagine there was a base metal as scarce as gold but with the following properties:

- boring grey in colour
- not a good conductor of electricity
- not particularly strong, but not ductile or easily malleable either
- not useful for any practical or ornamental purpose

and one special, magical property:

- can be transported over a communications channel

If it somehow acquired any value at all for whatever reason, then anyone wanting to transfer wealth over a long distance could buy some, transmit it, and have the recipient sell it.

Satoshi's Intent

What exactly was Satoshi Nakamoto trying to accomplish with Bitcoin? For that, we must dive into his writings and correspondences in the early days of the Bitcoin network. He was desperate to provide an alternative not only to financial institutions, but also to fiat currencies prone to devaluation by governments and central banks that replaced gold, an intent evident from his early emails and forum posts. On January 3, 2009, the first Bitcoin block ever mined by Satoshi himself included an embedded message into the genesis block:

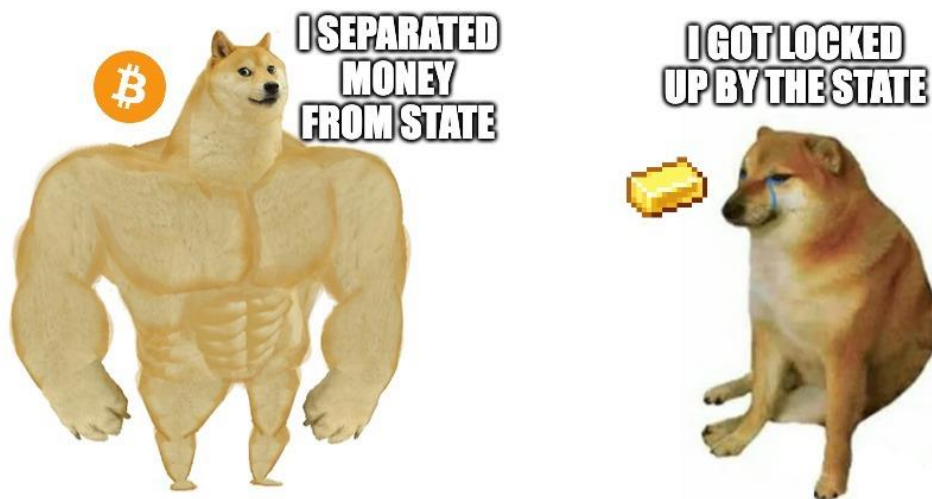
The Times 03/Jan/2009 Chancellor on brink of second bailout for banks.

The events of the great financial crisis must have been highly antagonistic to the creator of Bitcoin, for him to place a British newspaper headline about the ongoing financial crisis directly into the ledger's permanent record. By embedding this cryptic message, he proposed a decentralised and transparent system of money and transactions that offered a necessary evolution and a potential solution to the centralised, enigmatic, and bailout-prone international banking system.

After Bitcoin had been up and running for a few weeks, Satoshi provided a little more detail on his motivations for the project and demonstrated an acute awareness of the instability of credit-money systems, fractionally reserved layers of the fiat money pyramid, and the authority and abuse of fiat by whoever has authority over it:

The root problem with conventional currency is all the trust that's required to make it work. The central bank must be trusted not to debase the currency, but the history of fiat currencies is full of breaches of that trust. Banks must be trusted to hold our money and transfer it electronically, but they lend it out in waves of credit bubbles with barely a fraction in reserve.

Satoshi revealed his ambitions for Bitcoin to exist as a currency, not solely as a payments network. Satoshi's criticism of fiat currencies demonstrated a cognisance of the instabilities within our fractionally reserved, layered-money system, under an authoritarian control within the jurisdiction of that fiat's monetary system, regardless of that state's political ideologies. In hindsight, the criticism does appear to have motivated him to create Bitcoin. Perhaps the fabricator wanted to provide the world with a new first-layer money free from the control and corruption of any state, entity, or individual [19].



Chapter 7

Stories and Testimonies

Since its inception, Bitcoin has served and continues to serve many uses in cases where current systems have failed, for people most disenfranchised or excluded by current monetary and banking systems of the world, or when such systems have been weaponised against individuals or nations. As of 2021, around 1.4 billion people across the globe (roughly 1 in 5 of the global population) remain unbanked and lack access to financial services [20].

The right and access to personal sovereign banking of one's funds is only one of many value propositions Bitcoin offers. Over the years, Bitcoin's use cases have tangibly helped the lives of many. The following are only a few of the stories and testimonies of how Bitcoin has served as a life raft, economically empowering individuals, groups, and communities around the globe in the face of monetary crises, economic repression, persecution, and tyranny.

In each of their stories, we will see how Bitcoin, contrary to fiat money (and the mark of the beast to a much greater extent), seeks to impose itself on no one. Moreover, as it has grown and monetized, it continues to distinguish itself as a peaceful, neutral, and uncensorable monetary technology. It is never forced on others, but is always just there, available to anyone, anytime, anywhere to use as a liquid store of value beyond the reach of government control and censorship.

Kal – Bitcoin in Ethiopia

This interview features a young Bitcoiner in Ethiopia and offers a firsthand look at personal experiences with Bitcoin in Ethiopia. Demonstrating how a neutral, permissionless monetary technology intersects with everyday life in challenging economic and political environments.

For Kal Kassa in Ethiopia, Bitcoin is about bridging the gap between the upper and lower classes in a corrupt system. "Wages do grow, but not on par with inflation. Salaries in urban areas have perhaps double over the past decade, but goods have gone up by 3 to 5 times. The upper classes use the dollar as their unit of account, but the poor outside the city, well, dollars are official illegal for them."

Kal's brother was arrest for simply have a \$20 bill in his pocket, but the arrest wasn't enough to stop Kal. "I created a Telegram group where I pay freelancers, graphic designers, and translators based in Ethiopic, with bitcoins." In America, most people treat Bitcoin as an investment, or as a savings account, but here, I use it as a medium of exchange. It's a part of my life.

– Kal Kassa, Human Rights Foundation [21]

Fadey - A Young Refugee

During the Russo-Ukrainian war, displaced persons and refugees fled from the conflict with their savings in Bitcoin, carrying their hardware wallets or committing their Bitcoin seed phrase to memory.

Fadey also took a USB stick with him across the border containing 40% of his life savings, or about \$2,000 in bitcoin. That thumb drive, combined with a unique passcode, became the key to his financial survival. “I could just write my seed phrase on a piece of paper and take it with me,” explained Fadey. His experience highlights some of the most important characteristics of bitcoin: It’s valid across borders, requires no bank, and is tethered to its owner by a password, making it a lot harder to steal than cash.

– CNBC, story of Fadey, a young Ukrainian refugee [22]

Carlos - Borderless Money

Helping individuals and families in Venezuela to survive a collapsing national currency, and empowering Venezuelans to flee economic repression without having their money seized by the authorities.

Venezuelan military personnel have a reputation for seizing the money of people who want to leave, but Juan’s being in Bitcoin, was accessible only with a password he had memorised, writes Hernández and adds: ‘Borderless money’ is more than a buzzword for those of us who live in a collapsing economy and a collapsing dictatorship.

– Carlos Hernández, Venezuelan economist [23]

Win – Political Exile and Economic Exit

Enabling Burmese refugees to bypass state-frozen bank accounts and transport their wealth across borders without physical assets or government permission. For those like Win Ko Ko Aung, Bitcoin provided a critical financial lifeline, allowing them to reclaim their autonomy even while exiled by an authoritarian regime.

I was a social entrepreneur, a public figure, and the author of one of Burma’s best-selling books in 2020 titled “A 21st Century Burmese Guy.” I used my voice and platform to speak out against the military coup and mobilize peaceful resistance — and paid the price. My bank accounts were frozen, and I was charged with Section 505(A) of the Penal Code — a law criminalizing free speech, which put my life at risk. I fled without even having time to grab my passport and crossed the Burmese border into Thailand, hiding among migrant labourers to avoid being captured.

I made it to the US with almost nothing — except a small amount of Bitcoin I had once bought out of curiosity. With my money trapped back home, Bitcoin helped me survive. That experience became the foundation of my work at Human Rights Foundation, where I now help others learn to use Bitcoin as a tool for financial freedom. All while being in exile.

In contrast to state-controlled [digital] money like CBDCs, Bitcoin offers something unique: unstoppable, uncensorable, permissionless money. It operates outside the reach of both authoritarian regimes and central banks. For people living under dictatorship, it’s a tool for financial autonomy and freedom.

– Win Ko Ko Aung, Burmese author and human rights activist [24]

Fereshteh – An Economic Lifeline

In Afghanistan, serving as an essential payment channel that bypasses economic sanctions design to cripple the economic life of Afghans and restrictive local bank withdrawal limits amid a food security crisis. By utilising digital currency, vulnerable individuals, particularly Afghan women, were able to receive emergency funds and carried their wealth with them even if displaced.

The value of the currency tanking combined with the price of household essentials rocketing has led to widespread food insecurity, Insider reported. With foreign aid suspended, an overwhelming majority (98%) of Afghans don't have enough to eat, according to the World Food Programme.

The situation is particularly "horrific" for the nation's women, Forough said, many of whom have been forced out of jobs and into poverty. On top of being desperately hungry, she explained that many of her female students have struggled to pay for medicine and internet access.

Forough said she wanted to send emergency payments to these women, but, frustratingly, most of her transactions were blocked by Western Union and JPMorganChase. Once some of the money did eventually go through, often, her students were unable to withdraw cash at local banks.

Forough said that donating cryptocurrencies holds many advantages for the women in Afghanistan, including a reduced risk in the money being confiscated. "And if they got displaced from Afghanistan or any part of Afghanistan, they can also carry their finances with themselves everywhere they go," she continued. "That, to me, is empowering."

– Business Insider, Fereshteh Forough, founder of Code to Inspire in Herat, Afghanistan [25]

Tony - Sovereignty Over Savings

The exit and life raft to economic survival amidst a concurrent economic, monetary, and banking crisis in Lebanon, where banks severely restricted access to savings amid the currency collapse of the Lebanese pound.

In 2019, Lebanon's banks began restricting access to savings, imposing informal capital controls without any legal framework. "Overnight, people lost access to their funds," Tony says. "You couldn't withdraw your own money, and even if you could, it was in Lebanese pounds that were rapidly losing value."

In early 2020, Lebanon defaulted on its foreign debt, and the value of the Lebanese pound plummeted. Hyperinflation set in, destroying the purchasing power of ordinary people. Tony watched helplessly as his savings evaporated and his businesses crumbled. "I went from being a successful entrepreneur to having just \$70 to my name in what felt like the blink of an eye," he recalls. "I couldn't pay rent, school fees, or even afford basic groceries... If I had known about Bitcoin before the crisis, it could have saved me, Bitcoin would have given me a way to store value outside the banking system, which completely failed. I wouldn't have

been locked out of my own savings, and I could have preserved my wealth as the Lebanese pound collapsed... Bitcoin isn't tied to any government or central bank, so it can't be manipulated the way the Lebanese pound was, it's a hedge against hyperinflation, which would have been critical when prices were doubling and tripling every few months."

Tony's experience is a stark reminder of the fragility of fiat systems and the importance of financial sovereignty. "With bitcoin in your custody, you have the power to protect yourself from corruption, manipulation, and inflation," Tony says. "You don't need permission from a bank or a government to manage your own money. And that's exactly what makes Bitcoin the ultimate tool for financial freedom."

– Bitcoin Magazine, Tony Yazbeck, entrepreneur & Bitcoin educator [26]

Dichter – Freezing the Freedom Convoy

Moreover, even in well-established democracies, monetary and banking systems still nonetheless remain powerful tools that can be weaponised against the citizenry to enforce the government's interest. When the Canadian government invoked the Emergencies Act to directly freeze bank accounts of protesters of the Freedom Convoy and pressure crowdfunding platforms like GoFundMe, organisers turned to Bitcoin as a lifeline for truckers and their families.

And through it all, the Freedom Convoy quickly became one of the most high-profile test cases for the use of Bitcoin as a permissionless and censorship-resistant way of transacting value to whomever, wherever, whenever.

"This will be a historical moment for Bitcoin," explained B.J. Dichter, a Toronto resident born and raised in Canada, who was a long-haul trucker himself before becoming a spokesperson for the Freedom Convoy. "Because we always talked about this hypothetical, the government tyranny of blocking your bank accounts, stealing your money and whatever... Well, now they just did. So, it proved everything. Everything that people said about Bitcoin like, 'Oh, that's hyperbolic. That's never gonna happen.' Well, guess what? Yesterday's conspiracy is today's reality. And I think in the future, people are going to see, that was the moment that regular people and everybody understood that the government can't track it, can't block it, and shouldn't be able to."

On February 3, a committee from the Canadian House of Commons asked GoFundMe officials to testify over security concerns about where the donated funds were coming from and where they might be going. Members of Parliament also asked the Financial Transactions and Reports Analysis Centre of Canada (FINTRAC) to testify. The next day, GoFundMe removed the campaign.

Several other centralised fundraising platforms started collecting funds for the Freedom Convoy, but it was clear that the Canadian government had drawn a line in the sand. Fundraisers on Christian-focused donations platform GiveSendGo had collected more than \$8.5 million for the protestors, but the Ontario Superior Court of Justice granted a court order to freeze the funds. By late February, Canada had invoked the Emergencies Act and had frozen more than 75 bank accounts linked to the protests.

“Three years ago, if you had asked me what’s the chance that Canada would freeze individuals’ bank accounts... I’d find it really hard to believe it was 20%,” said Greg Foss, an outspoken Bitcoin advocate and fifth-generation Canadian. “And three years later, it’s 100%... It was not a good thing for [the country’s] freedom.”

The saga served as one of the most high-profile test cases for Bitcoin as a sovereign financial rail in its thirteen-year history. As Bitcoiners continue to tout the technology as an off-ramp from undue censorship and surveillance, its use as a system for getting hundreds of thousands of dollars in value directly into the hands of those who had been blacklisted by the Canadian government may be the most potent illustration of that power to date. Perhaps most significantly of all, it demonstrated on the world stage that fiat can only be used how governments decide.

– B.J. Dichter & Greg Foss, Bitcoin Magazine [27]

Yeonmi – From Silence to Sovereign

Last but not least, the author would like to share the powerful testimony of Yeonmi Park in her conversation with humanitarian worker Alex Gladstein at the 2022 Miami Bitcoin Conference. Having escaped North Korea, she survived to tell the tales of the Hermit Kingdom’s use of economic repression to enforce state loyalty, and the exploitation of defectors in China left vulnerable by financial disenfranchisement. In contrast to this darkness, she explains how Bitcoin is empowering North Korean women and their children through church communities. Ultimately, her description of the state’s total control over money stands as a microcosm of the tyranny of that of the Antichrist’s to come.

Yeonmi Park: I’m so grateful talk about Bitcoin and also freedom... I remember when I was young the government was telling people that you should deposit money in the bank and then people did because we trusted our dear leader, I mean he was our god to us. Once we put our money in the bank account it was locked nobody could get the money out of the bank accounts, only people who had the connection to the bankers and the government officials who could get the money out and so this is a real struggle right in North Korea. Private Property is banned you cannot own a car, you cannot own a house, you cannot own anything, so therefore if you make a [transaction of] money in the black-market system, you have to that money hide somewhere [back] in your house.

One time actually I remember my mother’s best friend, there’s many thieves in North Korea, she was hiding the cash, the hard earned the cash inside of where she was cooking food, and the husband came without knowing and burned the whole thing, so her life savings [just] gone like that. In North Korea because we don’t know how to hide the cash, I still remember my mother would take the stockings out and put the cash and wrapping around her body to hide the money because that was the only way we could carry cash.

By 2009, we all know that North Korea strived to become a socialist paradise where there’s no inequality, so the regime decided how are we going to make everybody “equal”, is they designed in 2009 we are going to do something called the “currency exchange”, which means previous money that you had will worth nothing, literally [became worthless].

Alex Gladstein: That people had been saving for decades...

YP: Yes, in a black market for like 70 years people working the black markets and saving this money, and the regime wanted to make sure that everybody is “equal” and take all the power from North Korean people so they did something called the “currency exchange”, and they said each family now they give them only one week seven days...

AG: One week, you had one week to turn in your old money?

YP: Yes, and they said and for the people in Pyongyang, the people [in the countryside] only three days. Each family can only get new cash that was worth of buying two kilograms of rice. So regardless how much [old North Korean won] you have, your money meant nothing the next day. After that “currency exchange”, the people now actually do not have any money and they are actually trying to find a way to get alternative moneys.

AG: So the regime found a very cruel way to try to make everyone equal... What you just described in 2009 was is known as demonetisation. So cash can help people and it does help people around the world, a lot of people save around the world especially in dollars under their mattress or somewhere in their house but there's a there's a very cruel way that the government can even take that from you, and that's again called demonetisation: where they say “oh all that money that's no longer worth anything anymore”. And as you're just telling us they only gave people a week or even a few days depending on which caste system you were in North Korea... Basically you only have a certain amount of time to turn that in and then in exchange you'll get this new money but you can only get a certain amount. So I mean we don't often hear about finance and economics and money in in the human rights discussions, you know I worked on North Korea issues for years and years and years and never heard about this or learned about this until I started asking questions about Bitcoin and money. And in that vein, when you were growing up, did they teach you about money in school?

YP: No, the word in North Korea “profit” is banned, I mean they think money as evil and any business enterprise private business is evil so they don't teach us anything about economy and money. So basically what people, what we have to do is relying on the government who is going to give us public rations, but they didn't do that, so our only choice was dying from starvation, and that's [why] I escaped from North Korea when I was 13 years old.

AG: Can you talk a little bit about the role that money played in in your escape at all? And maybe how it was a limiting factor or how you wish you had a different kind of money? Take us through that a little bit.

YP: Yeah I think it's so surreal for me coming from North Korea actually sitting in Miami, this very liberal place right now it is full of electricity... But when I escaped from North Korea at 13, I arrived in China, and they sold me for less than 300 dollars as a sex slave, and there are right now 300,000 North Korean women in China [that] are being sold. The reason why we are being sold is because we [are debanked and] cannot have bank accounts. And when North

Korean women get captured and sent back, if they somehow able to hide 50 dollars they don't have to die in the prison camp, but the regime is so vicious, they even check everybody part [of your body]. You cannot even imagine, and they even check after you go to bathroom so there's no way you can hide anything or jewelry or money in your body. But something like Bitcoin, if you remember your [seed phrase] you go out, you talk to a broker, they give you the money and you can come out. But because North Koreans has no [and doesn't know a] medium like that, they've been suffering and dying from this tragedy.

AG: I think what Yeonmi has been describing is kind of the end game of fiat money is a totally centrally planned money system that the rulers can arbitrarily change at any time, and that's what the North Korean people have had to endure. So Yeonmi, you told me something very interesting about how some people in China are using Bitcoin to help aid North Koreans who are stuck there... again let's remember people like Yeonmi who escaped into China don't necessarily speak Chinese, they've never been to these places before, and 70% of the people who escape are women and they're trafficked or interned in some way. They have no bank account they have no access to any sort of [fiat] money system. So Yeonmi can you walk us through how you've heard that Bitcoin is kind of penetrating through this system?

YP: Yeah I mean actually I'm sure not a lot of us haven't seen a North Korean before right? Because right now there are only 209 North Korean defectors [who have] made it to America during the last 80 years. So most of North Koreans when they escape they do not end up like me in America...

AG: Or even in South Korea most don't make it most get stuck in China or die...

YP: Right so they end up in China and [the Chinese government] they do not want to help these people. And not only that China had one child policy, because of that they have 30 million men [who] cannot find [a spouse], especially in Northeastern China which borders North Korea... So they buy North Korean girls like me as their sex slaves. And when these women go to and meet their supposedly Chinese husbands, they have a child. If the women get captured and send back North Korea, mothers [will be] sent to prison camps and die, and child... The problem is [the child] cannot get a state ID, the Chinese government does not accept the child as a Chinese so they become stateless children. And these children without ID [in Chinese called Hukou] they cannot even go to elementary school. So there are three hundred thousand North Korean women right now in China and the children are about up to like a million of them, we don't know quite fully how many are there. So now there are underground church groups starting a kind of homeschooling, sending bitcoins to a Chinese broker and they buy school supplies to children who cannot go to elementary school, so they don't [also] end up being trafficked and going to brothels and become a prostitute, so they can get educated and find a way out. And there's a way that we can empower these women and children through Bitcoin.

AG: I had mentioned to you earlier today that when I first met you seven or eight years ago uh how crazy is it that one day we'd be speaking together at a Bitcoin conference. You didn't know what Bitcoin was at the time and now you've been studying it you know a lot about it,

what do you think if you could go back to North Korea and start telling people that there's this currency that's digital that governments don't control? I mean once that starts to pick up traction inside North Korea what do you think will happen?

YP: I think that's the thing, when this morning we had talked about how the fiat currency, under fiat currency 169 million people died right? Like in my life nothing has been more evil than [my] government has been. I think the North Korean regime is almost testament how evil a government can be to individuals, so I think if the North Korean people know there's a way that they can have their own autonomy to decide what money they can use, I think you we will see a different world that we cannot even possibly fathom right now because we've been always under this government's control and we imagine that individuals have that power in our hands we can create a much better world [in which] nobody needs to be [enslaved].

– Yeonmi Park & Alex Gladstein, Bitcoin Conference 2022 [28]

Foreshadows of the Beast

Yeonmi, Tony, Dichter, Fereshteh, Win, Carlos, and Fadey's stories are just a few voices among the millions across the globe who have faced, and are facing, financial and economic repression and disenfranchisement. Though they are from different parts of the world, across distinct cultures, ethnicities, languages, and continents, their stories unite around one notion that loudly echoes the economic reality of the mark of the beast: the weaponisation of money to serve the interests of the state.

And he causes all, the small and the great, and the rich and the poor, and the freemen and the slaves, to be given a mark on their right hand or on their forehead, and that no one may be able to buy or sell except him who has the mark, that is, the name of the beast or the number of his name.

– Revelation 13:16-17

Each of their account offers a glimpse into the future of the world under the Antichrist's control and tyranny. Similar to Fereshteh's account, there will be famine and starvation in the end times (Matt. 24:7; Luke 21:11). Similar to Fadey's account, there will be conflict and wars (Matt. 24:7; Dan. 7:21; Rev. 13:7). Similar to Win's account, there will be fleeing and exodus of people from organised persecutions by the beastly government (cf. Mark. 13:14; Rev. 12:6; 20:4).

Similar to all their accounts, we would certainly expect the confiscation and freezing of money in the savings and bank accounts of all who do not comply to the Antichrist's government and receive the mark of the beast. The weaponisation of fiat monetary systems and rails against all (Rev. 13:16) to enforce absolute loyalty and control of the citizenry to the government and the Antichrist.

One should not feel contempt just because they are privileged to live in a developed nation and have never personally experienced a fiat currency collapse or disenfranchisement from the monetary and banking system. We know that when the Antichrist comes and takes power over the world, all will be economically disenfranchised regardless of one's age, economic status, social status, race, and nationality (Rev. 13:7, 16-17). As the centrepiece of the Antichrist's schemes, the mark will serve a most incisive purpose of immediately revealing to all (most

importantly to the Antichrist) those who are loyal, and those who are not to the Antichrist. Forcing a very immediate and fateful decision to receive the mark as the display of one's submission and loyalty to the Antichrist, to face social and economic persecution, and even death (cf. Rev. 20:4). Thereby deceiving many into receiving the mark of the beast (Rev. 19:20) with the pretence of granted economic survival, yet unaware of the eternal consequences of this action (Rev. 14:9-11).

We began the book by identifying and analysing the problem, methodically arriving at a solution, and now seeing the efficacy and real-world trials of Bitcoin against the problem(s) it was created by its creator to solve. Whether if you are a Christian know that this problem will be very real in the foreseeable future as the Antichrist and the mark of the beast must come before the coming of the true Christ, but do not know how rest of the billions and billions of people would make it through those fateful three and a half years without the ability to buy or sell. Or, you are a seasoned Bitcoin veteran who has survived multiple cycles and runs their own lightning node, you know that Bitcoin is **the** uncensorable, unstoppable freedom money, but have not fully grasped the true scale of the problem that Bitcoin proposes to solve until picking up this book.

Masters never don't do the basics, nor can one achieve the level of mastery by skipping over them. Respecting and making known the tried-and-true methods and know-how that got us where we are as Bitcoiners will probably help many others learn how to use Bitcoin. Without further ado, let us continue to the final, but perhaps the most important chapter of this book: the basics of using Bitcoin.

Chapter 8

Bitcoin Manual for Dummies

For the final chapter of this book, the author would like to present a broad and elementary overview of the practical application of Bitcoin. Understanding the Bitcoin whitepaper's breakthrough, its monetary properties, the biblical context, and seeing its real-world efficacy paves the foundation for understanding its role and effectiveness against the economic significance of the mark of the beast. Still, knowledge alone is not sufficient to constitute a solution without application.

One will never receive the benefit of a tool without learning to use it, as looking under the hood of a car and studying its engine components will never be as effective as manoeuvring the wheel and the pedals to get from one location to another. Whilst the author will not go into the greatest detail on every component under the hood, this final chapter will, in a most understandable way, explain the core components of Bitcoin and their respective applications for day-to-day use of storing and transacting value. Kind of like a user manual of Bitcoin for dummies.

That said, the information within this chapter is non-authoritative, only for reference, and provides a birds-eye overview to the nuances of practically using Bitcoin. Every part of Bitcoin's application (and in fact, any technology for this matter) is subjective and circumstantial and should not be taken as gospel. And like any other manual, it can be read through from start to finish to provide a bird's-eye overview, but may be most useful when consulted selectively, as specific needs arise.

Storing & Self-Custodying Bitcoin

The word "Bitcoin" officially refers to two things:

- 1) The Bitcoin software protocol: Bitcoin
- 2) The monetary unit within Bitcoin's software protocol:
 - Singular: 1 bitcoin, 1 BTC
 - Plural: 2 bitcoins, 2 BTC

Being an owner and self-custodying your bitcoins means true freedom from banks' control, government restrictions, and the degradation of fiat. Bitcoin recovers back all the power you should have over your money, but that also means no one else is responsible for your money, except yourself. With full sovereignty also comes full responsibilities.

To be able to possess bitcoins and use them for future transactions, you must first have a Bitcoin wallet. A Bitcoin wallet is how you interact with the Bitcoin network. Consider how you would select a Bitcoin wallet; it is analogous to how you would like to store your physical gold and silver. A small purse should suffice for a small enough amount to carry for interacting with merchants and purchasing daily necessities, while a larger vault should remain disconnected from the outside world for storing larger amounts of one's funds.

This section will go through what kind of Bitcoin wallets there are, the utility of different types of wallets, good practices, and common pitfalls of using your own wallet to self-custody bitcoins. Note that Bitcoin is NOT stored in your wallet, your private key is stored in your wallet, giving you access to your bitcoins on the Bitcoin blockchain.

Key words

- **Custodial:** A third party (like a wallet provider) holds the keys for you as an intermediary. You do not self-custody your own funds when you deposit bitcoins into a custodial wallet.
- **Non-custodial:** You alone hold the private keys. No bank intermediary is between you and your funds, but if you lose your keys, there is no customer support.
- **Private key:** A secret, 256-bit number that allows you to spend bitcoins from the wallet. If someone has your private key, they have your bitcoins. In a wallet, this is usually hidden behind a seed phrase.
- **Seed phrase (recovery phrase):** A list of 12 or 24 random words that acts as a human-readable private key. It can recreate your entire wallet and all its addresses if your wallet app/device is lost, hence also known as a recovery phrase. Once you commit your seed phrase to memory, your brain essentially becomes also a “wallet”.
- **Public key:** A large number mathematically derived from the private key. It is used to generate addresses for receiving, storing, and sending your bitcoins.
- **Wallet address(es):** A shorter, hashed version of your public key (e.g., bc1q...). Think of this as your “mailbox” address. You give this to others so they can send you bitcoins.
- **Wallet password/ pin:** The password to access the wallet, similar to your phone’s password to prevent strangers from immediately accessing your device in case of loss or theft. You do not lose your funds if you forget the pin.
- **Passphrase:** An optional phrase (like “13th” or “25th” word to the seed phrase) that adds a new wallet as an additional layer of protection to your funds, but if you forget the passphrase, you lose all the funds in that passphrase wallet.
- **UTXOs (Unspent Transaction Outputs):** Your wallet is a collection of “digital chunks” of bitcoins (UTXOs) from previous transactions. Think of it as nuggets of gold varying in weights in your pouch.

Software wallets

Software wallets, known also as hot wallets or soft wallets, are wallets that are connected to the internet and exclusive as a software on your device.

Typical attributes of software wallets being:

Pros	Cons
- Easy to setup - Convenient to use - User friendly - Free to download - Can recovery one’s refunds with wallet provider if custodial	- Greater surface of attack, susceptible to hacking, phishing, malware, and other cyber threats - Requires trust if custodial

Software wallets are ideal for storing insignificant amounts of BTC for everyday transactions, akin to having \$200 of cash in your physical wallet. But it is not recommended to be used to store a significant amount of bitcoins for the user. Users typically install software wallets on their

mobile phones as mobile, carry-on wallets used in tandem with Lightning payments (which we will soon cover).

It is the author's recommendation to prioritise non-custodial over custodial wallets if you desire to maximise the sovereignty of your funds, as you will retain your private key as a seed phrase. However, if you are not yet confident to fully custody your funds or find the need to protect a seed phrase for a relatively small quantity of funds inconvenient, custodial software wallets are also fine for starting off. In the Freedom Convoy's story from the previous chapter, when the Canadian court requested the non-custodial wallet provider Nunchuk to freeze the funds of the protesters, the following was the company's reply:

We do not collect any user identification information... We cannot freeze our users' assets. We cannot prevent them from being moved. We have no knowledge of the existence, nature, value and location of our users' local assets. This is by design. [27]

When choosing a software wallet for use, the author highly recommend choosing wallets that satisfy the following:

- **Open-sourced:** The source code for the software is fully published on a public online platform like GitHub to ensure there are no "backdoors" in the software.
- **Bitcoin-only:** Bitcoin-only software minimises the attack surface of the software. Wallets that support thousands of random cryptocurrencies are less secure and more prone to bugs.
- **Lightning Integration:** Enables instantaneous payments of bitcoins from A to B, necessary for users who make payments from their software wallets.
- **Non-custodial:** You hold the seed phrase; the developers have zero knowledge, control, and access to your funds.

Software wallets can also exist on desktops, such as Sparrow Wallet, which is desktop-exclusive and considered the 'gold standard' by many Bitcoiners (this is not an endorsement). Some software wallets (especially desktop ones) can be used in tandem with a hardware wallet, in which case they serve as a user interface for the hardware wallet.

Hardware Wallets

Hardware wallets, known also as cold wallets or hard wallets, are wallets that are NOT connected to the internet and are almost exclusively non-custodial, programmed to randomly generate your recovery seed (containing your private key) without an internet connection.

Typical attributes of hardware wallets being:

Pros	Cons
- Significantly more secure - Users retain full control over keys and funds - Enables layered protection (passphrase)	- Costs money (between \$60 to \$200) - Less convenient for payments (trade off with greater security) - Not as beginner friendly as soft wallets

	- Requires careful backup of recovery seed
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Hardware wallets are ideal for storing significant amounts of BTC for long-term savings. If a software wallet is your digital purse, then a hardware wallet is your digital vault. To use hardware wallets, users typically install a desktop software wallet to act as a software coordinator (user interface) for the hardware wallet.

When choosing a hardware wallet for purchase and use, the author highly recommends the following features and practices:

- **Open-sourced (or source-viewable):** The source code for the native software is fully published to ensure there are no “backdoors” in the devices’ software.
- **Bitcoin-only:** Bitcoin-only software minimises the attack surface of hardware’s official software.
- **Buy Direct:** Only buy directly from the manufacturer (e.g., Coinkite, Trezor, Blockstream). Never buy from Amazon or eBay, as the device could be tampered with.
- **Verify the Packaging:** Check for broken security seals. When you plug it in, most devices will run a “genuineness check” automatically via their official software.
- **Random Seed Generation:** If the device comes with a pre-loaded recovery seed that already has words printed on it, it is a scam. You must generate your own 12 or 24 words on the device itself.

Tutorials on wallets of your choice can be found online and on YouTube, a channel of recommendation is ‘BTCSessions’ by a passionate team of Bitcoin educators from Canada.

Private Key Management

If your Bitcoin wallet is a vault, the **private key** is the actual combination that unlocks it. However, because a raw private key looks like a terrifying string of 64 random letters and numbers, almost all modern wallets use a **seed phrase** (also known as a recovery phrase or recovery seed). Your seed phrase grants you access to your funds when entered into any wallet, software or hardware. Keep it safe.

When you create a Bitcoin wallet, you will typically write down a 12 or 24 word seed backup. This seed phrase is a mnemonic form of your private key. Akin to the key to the front door of your home, whoever has the key has access to what it unlocks. Remember and protect your key at all costs.

While there have been a handful of Bitcoin thefts from third-party hacks over the decade, the overwhelming reported losses of bitcoins are due to people taking inadequate care, steps, and effort in remembering, protecting, and backing up their seed phrase. Self-custodying bitcoins grants you full sovereignty over your own funds, and that is the point as an uncensorable, unconfiscatable money, but you also bear all the responsibility for your funds. Unlike a bank account where the bankers hold your funds, there’s no custodial recovery available for self-custodied wallets. Always remember:

Not your keys, not your coins.

Managing your private key is the most important responsibility in Bitcoin. Since there is no "Forgot Password" button in a non-custodial world, it is highly recommended to follow these "never-break" rules:

1. **Never “digitise” your seed:** Never take a photo or screenshot of your seed phrase, or save it in a Notes app, or email it to yourself, or store it in the cloud. Your seed phrase should **never** interact with the internet or any external device to the hardware wallet (that is the point of hardware wallets’ design). Hackers use automated tools to scan for 12-word patterns in leaked databases. Keep it physical.
2. **The medium:** While your wallet might come with a cardboard “Recovery Card”, paper is fragile. It can be destroyed by fire, humidity, or even curious pets.
 - For soft wallets with insignificant amounts, paper backup stored in a secure, dry place is usually fine.
 - For hard wallets with more significant amounts, consider a stainless steel backup. These are small metal plates where you stamp. They are fireproof and waterproof, ensuring your keys survive a house fire. A simple DIY setup can be a nut, bolt, and 12 or 24 washers.
3. **Secure location:** Make sure to store your physical seed at a secure location that only the owner of the funds knows and has access to.
 - Make it simple but secretive. The harder it is to find your seed phrase, the easier also it is for you to forget where it is. There is a trade-off.
 - Don’t split your 12 or 24 word seed phrase in separate locations. A good explanation to this is given by Andreas Antonopoulos (found in the Bitcoin Education Resources section).
4. **Commit to memory:** Arguably, long-term storage should be committed to long-term memory. One of the most powerful features of Bitcoin is that its seed phrase enables your brain to become a “wallet” once committed to memory, allowing anyone to take their bitcoins wherever they go (or flee to).
5. **Test recovery:** Before storing a significant amount of bitcoins in your wallet, it is good practice to store \$5 of bitcoin in your wallet first, and factory reset your wallet and “recover” it using your written seed phrase. If it works, you will know your backup is correct, so you don’t end up unknowingly storing an incorrect seed. Secondly, it demonstrates your funds are accessible on any wallet device using your seed phrase.
6. **Don’t store the seed phrase with passphrase at the same location:** See below.



Passphrases

The **passphrase** is one of the most misunderstood yet powerful tools within a Bitcoin wallet. You can think of it as the secret room in your house, or having a smaller vault within a vault. If your seed phrase is analogous to the key to your house, the passphrase is the secret door hidden behind the bookshelf. Optional, but allows even more security, and if you lose the “key” to your secret room, you get locked out of that room.

How It Works

When you add a passphrase to your seed phrase, the wallet's software performs a mathematical calculation to create a completely new and different wallet.

The following are examples of how passphrases work with a seed phrase (do not use these common passphrases yourself). You will see how passphrases theoretically enable an infinite number of 'secret rooms' to your wallet. But, as a housekeeper, the more keys you have to manage, the more tedious it becomes.

Passphrase A	Apple Pie#123
Passphrase B	apple pie#123
Passphrase C	applo pio#123
Passphrase D	ApplePie#123

Seed phrase = Wallet

Seed phrase + Passphrase A = Wallet A

Seed phrase + Passphrase B = Wallet B

Seed phrase + Passphrase C = Wallet C

Seed phrase + Passphrase D = Wallet D

Contrary to the seed phrase, the hardware wallet doesn't "store" the passphrase. It simply calculates a new set of addresses based on whatever words you type in. If you type a different passphrase, you get a different wallet.

Why Use a Passphrase

There are two main reasons Bitcoiners use passphrases:

Protection against physical theft: If a thief finds your seed phrase written on paper in your drawer, they will immediately try to sweep the funds. If you have a passphrase, the thief will only see the original wallet. Your funds behind a passphrase wallet are invisible to them unless they also know that passphrase. Hence, don't store your seed phrase with your passphrase together!

Duress Protection: If you are ever forced to unlock your wallet (the \$5 wrench attack scenario), you can give the attacker the pin to your "main" wallet which holds a small amount of "decoy" BTC. They leave satisfied, never knowing a much larger passphrase wallet exists.

The Double-Edged Sword

WARNING! The passphrase is one of the most common way people lose their Bitcoin. Because it is so powerful, it is also dangerous. There is no "reset" for a passphrase. If you forget it, or even if you misspell a single letter or capitalise something differently, you will be looking at a completely different, empty wallet. Your funds will be mathematically impossible to recover.

If you decide to use a passphrase for your storage, take note of the following:

- **Case sensitivity:** "Apple" is not the same as "apple". Every character, space, and symbol must be exact.

- **Don't overcomplicate it:** You don't need a 50-character passphrase, a few memorable words together do the job well (e.g. nervous-llama-eats-potato).
- **Commit to memory:** Like the seed phrase, commit to memory, but also have a physical backup.

	Seed Phrase	Passphrase
Generated by	The hardware device (randomly)	You (your choice)
Store it on	Paper/metal backup (and your brain)	Separate backup (and your brain)
If Lost	Funds in the non-passphrase wallet are lost	Funds in the passphrase wallet are lost

Multi-Signature (Advanced)

So far, we have covered storing and self-custodying one's funds with a single private key, that is, a single signature (one signature per private key). Multi-signature (multi-sig) is akin to having a vault that requires two or more keys to open; it is a way of securing bitcoins where more than one signature is required to move funds. It uses a mathematical rule called M-of-N, the most common being 2-of-3, you have 3 keys total and you need any 2 of them to send a transaction.

The practice of multi-signature self-custody significantly increases the security of one's funds against external threats, but equally the complexity of self-custody. Therefore, a multi-sig setup may not be necessary for most individuals, as a single-seed-phrase wallet with passphrase protection already provides ample security. Here are a few benefits and reasons for adopting multi-sig. Remember, as Bitcoin grants you full responsibility over your own funds, in self-custodying, you are often your own biggest threat.

- **No single point of failure:** In a single-sig wallet, if your seed phrase is compromised (without a passphrase), you lose everything. In multi-sig, an attacker needs to find multiple seed phrases in different locations.
- **Shared control:** Ideal for business partners or families. No one person can run off with the funds without the other's consent.
- **Physical protection:** You can keep one key at home, one in a safe deposit box, and one with a trusted lawyer/friend. A house fire or a burglary at one location won't result in lost funds.

Take extreme caution after you have mastered self-custody with a single-signature when considering progressing to multi-signature. Unless you are a well-known individual, or an organisation, or have multiple claims from other parties to your funds in addition to yourself, the author would not recommend a multi-sig setup for self-custodying for the average Joe.

Transacting with Bitcoin

Once sovereignly custodying and securing your bitcoins, you will also be able to sovereignly transact with them.

Let's explore different types of transactions, a general structure, and best practises.

On-Chain Transactions

This section of the manual focuses on the "base layer" of Bitcoin. While the Lightning Network is like a fast-moving stream for payments relatively small in size, on-chain transactions are the heavy-duty freight trains of the network, slightly slower, but incredibly secure and permanent. It is analogous to sending a mail, where you need to specify the exact address, the amount of funds, and pay a tiny fee (the stamp) for it to be delivered to the recipient.

How to Receive Bitcoin On-Chain

Receiving is the easiest way to start. From experience, most of the receiving is done in the context of withdrawing funds from a seller of bitcoin (i.e. an exchange). Below are the typical procedures.

1. Open your wallet and click "Receive".
2. Generate an Address: The wallet will show a QR code and a string of characters.
 - It's normal for this address to change every time you receive money; this is a privacy feature! It is like when you receive a piece of gold nugget into your pouch, it occupies another space, and doesn't amalgamate with the existing nuggets.
3. Share it: Copy-paste the address to the sender, or share the QR code. Best practice, also double check the last 6 letters of the pasted address against the copied address.

How to Send Bitcoin On-Chain

Sending requires more care because mistakes cannot be undone. As soon as a transaction is broadcast to the Bitcoin network, it's propagated to nodes and miners and cannot be reverted or cancelled. This is a fundamental property of Bitcoin's decentralised blockchain: no central authority can intervene to stop a transaction. Below are some typical procedures.

1. Open your wallet and click "Send".
2. Copy the recipient's address: Never type it out manually. Use a QR scanner or the copy-paste function. Below is a typical Bitcoin address and its corresponding QR code. Anyone who sees the address or the QR code can engage in direct economic transactions with the owner of the address. Example below.



`bc1qdt8y8jv5gmlmfal5f8f7xvqevtcz4xg6a95f3s`

3. Choose the Amount: You can usually toggle between the BTC amount and your local currency (e.g., USD).
4. Set the Fee: Your wallet will ask if you want it sent fast, medium, or slow. A higher fee prioritises your transaction, like a mail with a more expensive stamp.

5. **Verify & sign:** If using a hardware wallet, look at the device screen to make sure the address matches what is on your computer. Press “sign” or “confirm” to sign the transaction with your private key.
6. **Broadcast the transaction:** Some interfaces will require you to broadcast the transaction to the Bitcoin network. Once the transaction is broadcast to the Bitcoin network, it is irreversible.

Understanding Fees

On-chain fees are not based on the amount of money you send. Sending \$1 million costs close to the same as sending \$1. Instead, you pay for the space your transaction takes up on the Bitcoin ledger.

- Fees are measured in sat/vB (Satoshis per virtual Byte).
- Think of a block in Bitcoin’s blockchain like a bus with limited seats. If the bus is full, people will bid higher prices to get a seat on the next trip. Buses arrive and depart periodically on average every 10 minutes.

On-Chain Transacting Tips

- **Test small rule:** If you are sending a significant amount for the first time, send a tiny “test” amount first to ensure you have the process and the correct recipient address.
- **Check the Mempool:** You can visit websites like mempool.space to see how busy the network is, or the line for the next bus. If the station is not busy, you can set a very low fee and save money. Only do not enter your wallet address into public websites like mempool.space, as it might link your IP to that wallet address.
- Be aware of which UTXO you spent from which address, most wallets allow users to select UTXO(s) for sending.

UTXOs & Gold Nuggets

More technically speaking, the amount of BTC pertaining to a Bitcoin address is known as an UTXO (unspent transaction output) on the blockchain. The word “unspent” means that amount has not been spent from that address, hence it is available to be spent by the owner of that address.

As a parallel to gold, Bitcoin shares the similarity of being accounted for in digital weights. A single bitcoin can be thought of as weighted in 100,000,000 digital atoms (known as satoshis, abbreviated sats), and the sizes of bitcoins in the wallet’s addresses are known as UTXOs (think of it as a nugget). A piece of bitcoin UTXO one holds is akin to a gold nugget; both are unspent by the holder. In parallel, a nugget of gold (an UTXO of bitcoin) can be as small as a single atom (a single sat), or as big as 100 trillion atoms. And the value of the purse (wallet) is given as the total weight (quantity of sats) of all the gold nuggets (UTXOs) combined.

For security, and frankly, logical reasons, you wouldn’t take your biggest gold bar (bitcoin UTXO) with you to the market for transacting. It is as if handing the barista a \$1,000,000 note for a \$5 coffee purchase, you might get weird looks as they hand you back \$999,995 in change, and you have exposed yourself to the barista how ‘well-off’ you are. Therefore, it is highly advisable to choose which UTXO(s) of bitcoin to spend from when making an on-chain transaction.

Lightning Transactions

This section is arguably the “fun” part of the manual relative to previous sections focusing on storage and security, it will be about Bitcoin being digital cash in your pocket. The Lightning Network is a technological enhancement to Bitcoin that positively transforms it from a slower-moving first-layer money, like shipping physical gold to a second-layer currency moving at near lightspeed with instantaneous settlement.

However, the key difference between BTC and the Lightning network with the layered monetary system of gold and gold-backed paper notes is that the BTC on the first and second layers remains indistinguishable. It is akin the ability to convert any quantities of gold down to the exact unit of atoms into an electronic form, and zapping those e-Atoms across the globe at the speed of light, and the recipient able to convert the e-Atoms back into physical gold anytime at free will, or use it for further Lightning transactions; unlike gold and paper notes, bitcoins remains intrinsically same on both layers.

The Lightning Wallet

Bitcoin’s Lightning Network is typically integrated into soft wallets and is readily available on mobile phones, as it was designed for small and frequent transactions typically paid with bank cards. It is best to think of a Lightning wallet as giving your mobile phone the function of a digital wallet.

To set up for spending bitcoins via the Lightning Network, you will need to fund your Lightning-integrated soft wallet. This is typically done through an on-chain transaction from your non-Lightning wallet (cold or soft) to the Lightning-integrated soft wallet.

There are a few key concepts to know before transacting with the Lightning Network:

- **Sats (Satoshis):** On Lightning, we use Sats as the unit of account instead of BTC, as transactions are typically small in value. There are 100 million sats in one bitcoin. A cup of coffee might be 5,000 sats.
- **Invoices expire:** Unlike a regular Bitcoin address, a Lightning invoice is typically valid for only a few minutes or hours. If it expires, new ones can be generated at any moment.
- **Liquidity (the wiring):** If you have a non-custodial wallet, you might occasionally see a small fee to “open a channel”. This is just the cost of connecting your wallet to the global Lightning Network. Most modern wallets handle this automatically.

Sending And Receiving via Lightning

Sending and receiving in lightning transactions are very similar to on-chain, with the following differences:

- Lightning don’t usually use permanent addresses, but rather invoices
- Lightning transactions doesn’t require UTXO management
- Lightning transactions are near instant, with typically lower fees
- Designed for small, frequent transactions and fast payments
- Done mostly through QR codes

How to Receive via Lightning

1. Click “Receive” in your wallet
2. Set the amount for the invoice by typing in how much you want to receive
3. Share the QR code generated on your phone with the other person
4. As soon as the other person has paid, the wallet will notify you, and the sats you receive are available for on-chain and Lightning transactions immediately

How to Send via Lightning

1. The person you are paying will show you a QR code (an invoice)
2. In your Lightning-integrated wallet, hit “Send” and scan their QR code
3. Your wallet will show the amount (e.g., 5,000 sats). You hit “Pay” to confirm

Obtaining Bitcoin

This section concerns the moment you trade your local fiat currency for bitcoins. Because every country has different laws, and every individual’s circumstances are unique, this section focuses more on the framework and good practices for acquiring bitcoins, than on a specific approach.

Buying bitcoin is the only process in which you will encounter intermediaries, meaning third parties may be able to restrict what you can and cannot do with your money. Whenever you encounter difficulties in obtaining bitcoins with fiat, know that this is never the fault of Bitcoin, as any difficulty in obtaining of bitcoin with fiat is a testament to how fiat is ultimately a tool for control and restriction, with the ability to allow and restrict the purchase of certain things at the authority of the issuer of the fiat, and whoever custodies your fiat.

The Two Paths: KYC vs Non-KYC

There are two main ways to get Bitcoin. Think of the first as a convenient way, and the second as a private way. The convenient way, being centralised KYC exchanges, is the most common path, through using a regulated exchange.

- **KYC (Know Your Customer):** You must provide your national ID and a selfie to create an account. However, hardcore Bitcoiners refer to KYC as “kill your customer”, as exchanges are centralised counterparties and honeypots of personal information data, which are vulnerable to coercion from a higher authority, or data breaches of the personal information of their users.
- **The trade-off:** KYC exchanges are easy to use, but the exchange keeps a permanent record of every satoshi you buy, and may decide to freeze your funds or give away your personal information at their discretion (though not saying KYC exchanges are inherently malicious).
- **Crypto-casino:** KYC exchanges most often offer access to alternative cryptocurrencies, which are the brainchilds of centralised crypto venture capital projects destined to fail and provide no utility against the mark of the beast.

The private way, is buying directly from other people using online peer-to-peer platforms. Great tutorials and education for this method can be found in BTCsessions' YouTube tutorials and Plan B Academy.

- The trade-off: No personal identification is required, which protects your privacy. However, it has a steeper learning curve and requires more knowledge and “street smarts” to deal directly with a seller.

Good Practices

Withdrawal immediately: The most dangerous thing a dummy can do is leaving their funds on an exchange. Remember, not your keys, not your coins! An exchange is analogous to a public toilet; it is designed to be convenient and very useful when you need it, but once you are done with using it, you should leave as fast as possible. As soon as you buy your bitcoins, withdraw them to your wallet where you control the keys.

Beware of phishing: You may receive a message or email that sounds exactly like “Customer Support” or even a friend asking for your login. Ignore. Legitimate Bitcoin companies will never contact you to ask for your password, additional personal information, or your seed phrase.

Enable 2FA: Use an Authenticator App (like Google Authenticator) to secure your exchange account, if possible, to increase your account security.

Dollar Cost Averaging (DCA): Don't try to guess when the price is “low”. Successful Bitcoiners buy a small, set amount regularly, regardless of price (e.g. \$20 every week). This removes stress and builds your funds steadily over time.

Perform a small test: Buy a tiny amount first and practice withdrawing it to your wallet, to test the rails and familiarise yourself with the process.

Bitcoin Security Cheat Sheat

	NEVER	ALWAYS
Wallets & Self-custody	• Never use custodial wallets for long-term storage • Never pick your own 12 or 24 words seed phrase • For firmware updates of the hardware wallet, never click on links from any wallet/crypto-related email, but instead go to the manufacturer's website, and verify the PGP signatures for updates	• Always generate your seed offline randomly on the hardware wallet • Always only keep a small spending amount in hot wallets • Always buy the hardware wallet directly from the manufacturer, and if possible, order to a PO Box, or work address • Always use brand new factory-made hardware wallets
Seed Phrase Management	• Never store your seed phrase digitally or online, or type it on an external device • Never share your seed phrase with anyone else • Never store all seed backups in one location • Never store the seed phrase together with passphrase	• Always write seed phrases on paper and preferably metal plates (stainless steel) for durability • Always store copies in secure, hidden, separated locations • Always test recovery with insignificant funds (factory reset hard wallet) so you know your backups work • Always try to commit your seed phrase to memory (once doing all the above)
Passphrases	• Never store the passphrase together with seed phrase • Never forget your passphrase; if lost, funds behind the passphrase are irretrievable	• Always store it separately from your seed backups • Always try to commit your passphrase to memory
Transacting with Bitcoin	• Never send large amounts without testing first with a small amount • Never send without double-checking the pasted address with the copied address • Never make transactions from public WiFis or malware-infected devices	• Always transact through soft wallets; hard wallets are purposed exclusively for storage • Always double-check the destination address before sending • Always verify all addresses on the hardware wallet device screen • Always start with sending small test amounts for new recipients or large transactions • Always use trusted nodes and networks, and avoid sending via public WiFi without a VPN

Obtaining Bitcoin	• Never leave any amount of funds on exchanges indefinitely • Never provide any personal information or your seed phrase to “emails” or “requests” from any exchange	• Always buy from reputable exchanges or OTC services with good security records • Always transfer funds to your wallets immediately after purchase • Always assume all forms of contact from exchanges are scams
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Bitcoin Education Resources

A non-exhaustive list of Bitcoin education resources:

Bitcoin Education

- **BTCsessions & Zero2Hero:** A Bitcoin YouTube channel and educational website with practical, step-by-step video tutorials and structured courses designed to guide users from their first purchase to advanced self-custody and privacy techniques.
- **Plan B Academy:** A comprehensive educational platform dedicated to teaching Bitcoin, offering certified courses on Bitcoin’s economics, technology, and application, and tutorials on custodying, transacting, and buying. The Plan B Academy expands on all the points covered in this chapter, it is like a theme park for Bitcoin learning!
- **Saylor Academy:** a non-profit organisation established in 1999 that provides free, self-paced, online, and open university-level courses to learners worldwide. It offers specialised, free Bitcoin education, including courses like “Bitcoin for Everybody”.
- **Satoshi Nakamoto Institute:** A library and archive of essential cypherpunk literature, early Bitcoin communications, and technical papers to promote understanding of decentralised, peer-to-peer money.

Further Readings

- **The Bullish Case for Bitcoin** by Vijay Boyapati
- **Layered Money: From Gold and Dollars to Bitcoin and Central Bank Digital Currencies** by Nik Bhatia
- **The Bitcoin Standard** by Saifedean Ammous
- **Check Your Financial Privilege** by Alex Gladstein
- **Broken Money** by Lyn Alden

YouTube Channels

- **BTCsessions:** A channel specialising in practical, step-by-step video tutorials and hardware reviews designed to help users master all practical matters of Bitcoin self-custody and privacy.
- **Andreas Antonopoulos:** A channel featuring insightful talks and Q&As that explain the complex technical and social implications of Bitcoin in an accessible way.
- **The Exit Manual:** Just a guy trying to explain Bitcoin and share his stories and mistakes in his Bitcoin journey.
- **Bitcoin for the Lord:** Parodies that explain a most serious Biblical prophecy in the most humorous way.

Final Word from the Author

Congratulations, you made it to the end! Wow... I mean, thank you. Thank you, from the bottom of my heart. I don't know if this book will materially change the world in any way, especially when the Antichrist comes, only the Lord knows. But may it be acceptable to you, and to the Lord. For by the grace of God, I am what I am, and I have written when I have written. May His grace unto me not turn out to be vain, but on the contrary, I have written and laboured more abundantly out of my heart. Yet not I, but the grace of God which is with me. And may the God of peace Himself preserve your whole being completely, whether today, or during the times of the Antichrist, until the day of His return.

And do not be afraid of the Antichrist, for Christ has through death defeated death with the power of His resurrection and life, and if the world has received salvation through His death, much more will we be saved in His life. And He has promised to return to give all life to all who have received Him, to those who are living and those who are asleep. For if Christ does not return, the Antichrist will not come; if the Antichrist does not come, this book would not have been written.

The temporary solution to the mark of the beast may be Bitcoin, but the eternal solution is simply believing into Jesus and receiving Him as your Lord and Saviour, that all of your sins will be forgiven when you repent because Jesus Christ has already bore them on the cross and died for us, through Jesus and Jesus only can we be saved eternally and receive eternal life.

May you receive the true Christ by simply opening more of your heart to Him and receive Him as your Lord and Saviour, and the forgiveness of all of your sins. Now is the time of salvation! May the love of God, the grace of Christ, and the fellowship of the Holy Spirit be with you from now, until the return of our Lord Jesus Christ, until all eternity. Amen!

Sincerely,
The author.

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